

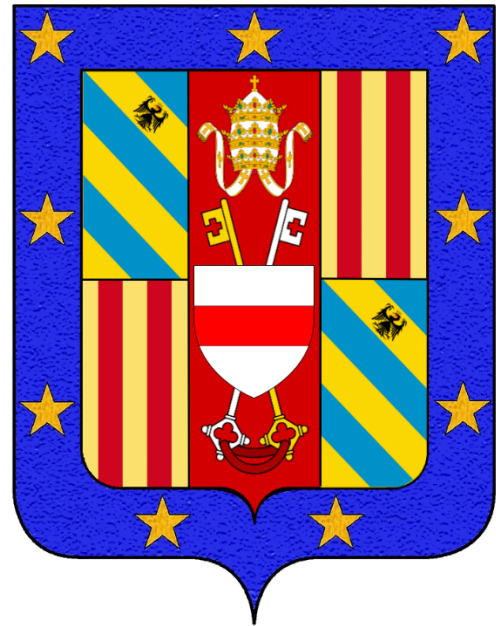
Name: Federico (da Montefeltro) **Sanseverino**,
Cardinal Deacon of San Teodoro
Age: 17 (and three quarters!)

From: Caiazzio, near Naples
Rank: Noble

Public Attributes: Freshly-appointed teenaged son of a celebrated mercenary general who died gloriously in battle, close relative of many mercenaries including the Sforza of Milan & Montefeltro of Urbino.

Private Attitude: They say there are two true tools of power in Italy, the crosier (bishop's staff) and the sword. Your family has thirty swords, and just one crosier: yours.

Your father was one of the greatest mercenary generals of the century, your ancestry reads like a catalog of famous knights, and through marriage there is not a single war leader of the noble Ghibelline faction that you cannot claim as kin. All three of your father's wives also came from warrior stock, and of the twenty-five siblings and half-siblings you know of (doubtless there are more you don't) most of your brothers are warriors or warriors in training, the eldest Gianfrancesco, Gaspare "Fracasso," and Galahad *Il Fortunato* already famous at the courts of France, the Emperor, and Milan respectively, while your ferocious sisters have married into many of the strongest families in Italy. Somebody had to be the family priest. You didn't want it to be you.



THE CASTLE BY THE SEA

Your father **Roberto Sanseverino d'Aragona, Marquis of Castelnuovo Scrivia (near Milan) and Count of Caiazzo (near Naples) and Colorno (near Mirandola)** earned his titles by his blade and lived and died in armor, slain when you were twelve in a last brave stand leading Venetian soldiers against Hapsburg ones in the mountainous border of the empire. The noble house of Sanseverino are descendants of the Dukes of Normandy, one of whose younger sons, Sir Turgisio (c. 1060 AD) earned the title Count of Sanseverino through heroic service. Your father far outshone his famous ancestor—they say in the end he fought on alone as his men fled, even after he lost an eye, and that it took two rifle shots, two deep sword-strikes, and a spear through the throat to finally bring him down. Every winter of your boyhood he rode home full of stories from the year's campaigns, and every spring he rode out splendid as Archangel Michael in his armor, pledging to return with his bright shield or on it. He broke that promise in the end—they never brought his body back home to Caiazzo where you waited, watching day by day as November sapped the azure from the glistening bay; your father's cousin-ally-rival-enemy Duke Ludovico Sforza had him buried in Milan to glorify the Sforza crypt, one more famed champion for that family of champions to boast about. Nothing but rumors came home.

Your mother died even earlier, your father's middle wife, **Elizabetta da Montefeltro**, called "**Bettina**", an illegitimate but recognized daughter of **Federico da Montefeltro Duke of**

Urbino, one of the greatest mercenaries of the century, rivaled only by the Sforza of Milan (whom you can claim as ancestors through three grandparents). You do remember Bettina da Montefeltro, the Queen of Summer in your memory as became sole sovereign of your castle and estates, you and your siblings racing to keep up as she dared you on to hunting, hawking, swimming, riding, spurring on her black mare to leap over fences that would daunt most men—it feels so dream-like that you can't be sure how much such memories are real, how much is just you *wanting* to remember her, and filling in from when her sisters (you have many aunts) have visited. You have memories too (or fantasies?) of winter nights standing on tiptoe to look across the grand oak feasting table, its polished surface shimmering in the light of the hall's great fire, your mother laughing as she took up one of the long German polearms your father brought back from his wars and made his efforts to snatch it back from her into kind of flirting dance—now, as a grown man, you doubt the castle hall was ever that big, or that Naples' frostless winters ever needed such a blaze.

You wanted to be like that. Like them. To ride into battle with such a weapon at your side and come home laughing. You were one of the youngest of your many siblings, born when your father was already fifty-seven, silver-haired like paintings of Saint Paul or royal Zeus. Your eldest half-brothers were already taking commissions from your parents' cousin the Sforza Duke of Milan, your nearer big brothers starting to ride in training armor. You begged to ride too. You were a better rider than they were, a natural your mother said. You kept asking and asking. For your sixth birthday your father figured it was close enough, and had a suit of armor made, the smallest ever seen in the Kingdom of Naples. You rode every day, twice most days, leaping fences, taking jousting runs at targets, spearing rings, racing along the sandy shore and hearing the salt splash tinkle on the steel like rain.

It took eight months for the pain to get really bad, the fire down your spine. You thought it was just exercise's normal fire, like how your arms burn after row-racing around the castle's moat, and get better after a day or two. It didn't stop. You couldn't sleep at night, woke your brothers yelping in pain each time you moved. You understand it now, the weight of armor compressing the spine, your father has it too, your elder brothers, uncles, constant pain, but somehow starting in armor at six, it was too young. You were still growing, and something grew wrong. Sometimes when you go swimming in warm weather, or in a long hot bath, or when you take trips to hot springs and feel weightless in those long, blissful soaks, then the fire stops, but the rest of the time, especially riding or sitting for too long, it burns. You're used to it, you rarely cry out now even when suddenly bumped into, but it's always burning, always there, and exertion makes it flare like a volcano. With a specialized saddle you could (and can still) ride *short* distances (less than a mile) without *overwhelming* pain, but if you put on armor, or you lift a sword or draw a bow, in seconds everything from tailbone to shoulder blade is a stripe of fire.

Within three months of the doctors giving up, you were an abbot. You didn't let anyone see you cry.

Your first Church office was a Benedictine abbey, somewhere near Milan, your first of many benefices bringing steady income to the family. You've never been there, no one expects you to, you never even put on a Benedictine robe until you set out for Rome at Pope Innocent's death. Your father kept coming home with stories—he'd left Sforza service after quarreling with Ludovico Sforza, then fought for Venice and Pope Sixtus near Ferrara, then when the pope switched sides fought *against* Venice for Pope Sixtus near Ferrara. Your eldest brothers had set out to make their own careers, sending back their stories, the eldest **Gianfrancesco** persuading Regent Ludovico and Duchess Bona of Milan to introduce him to the French Court, **Gaspere**

aka “**Fracasso**” making his name as a jousting champion. In winter their great feats joined the tales of your father’s, though he would pause sometimes to say that you “will soon outrank us all.” You’re good at forcing smiles. Summers were now ruled by your new stepmother **Lucrezia Malavolti, from Siena** (your father remarried soon after your mother’s death, a man of sixty but still active as a Hercules, and ready to father yet more strapping sons). Donna Lucrezia was both kind and fun, extremely learned and more charismatic than the musicians and entertainers that your father brought home among his trophies from the wars, and she paid more attention to you than to most of your brothers, watching every step of your education and the selection of your tutors, since, as she said, *you* were to advance the family’s standard with your wits instead of lances. You’re very good at forcing smiles.

When you were ten, your father’s prediction became secure. He left Venice’s service to fight for Pope Innocent VIII against King Ferrante of Naples in **the War of the Conspiracy of the Barons**, a war in which the house of Sanseverino played a great part, rising up against the oppressive king who sought to restrict their feudal rights within their territories within Naples. When things went badly and it looked like the pope would be entirely crushed, your father blackmailed the pope (he used the word ‘blackmailed’ himself when he told you!) threatening to abandon him mid-war if he didn’t promise you a cardinal’s hat. You were much too young to be a cardinal at once, of course, the deal was that Innocent would make you a *cardinal in pectore*, a name kept secret to be published upon his death. But it meant that, from age ten, as your brothers were first staining their swords with the blood of your Guelph rivals, you spent your hours with the clerks and scholars your father brought back from his conquests, on track to be a Prince of the Church, your cardinalship one of the greatest feats your father could boast of. That winter he started paying extra attention to you, enough to make your siblings envious, your father sitting you beside him for long evenings as he taught you to read through accounts, and the beginnings of how to read the subtext of the flowery language of the letters and dispatches of great men. A year later—1487—he was dead. So many visitors, coming to pay respects, so many warriors of many ages streaming in to honor the widow and sons of this great Ghibelline veteran—the sheer number of them gave you the first sense how large a thing your father had been part of, your mighty faction, custodians of the Caesars’ ancient empire alive in all these warriors’ hearts and deeds. All the visitors cheered on your brothers, how they were the image of your father, how his deeds would live in them. You sat in that bright hall, with all the shields and axes and helmets and other trophies of your father’s battles glinting on the walls, and felt like you were one of them, one more motionless remnant of someone great.

What helped you stop hating it so much?

Your aunts and uncles made the difference, so many of them, and so different.

Some of them are from your father’s line, or aunts and uncles by marriage through your elder half-siblings who are married already, but most of them (the most important ones) are through your mother. She had a lot of sisters, or half-sisters, actually. Your mother was a love child, conceived very early in the life of her father Federico da Montefeltro, before his childless first marriage, but she was always acknowledged, raised and loved by him, and was fifteen when her father married his second wife, **Battista Sforza**. Battista was something of a wonder woman, raised alongside Princess Ippolita Maria Sforza who married the Crown Prince of Naples, both girls raised by scholars to be fluent in Latin and ancient Greek, so Battista gave her first public address in Latin at the age of five! The marriage is a legend—the warrior Federico and his brilliant Sforza bride, “two souls in one body” it’s often said, and the famous warrior called her “the delight of both my public and my private hours,” so much that he took her with him on all

diplomatic visits (though not to his wars), and when she died, Federico da Montefeltro—conqueror and man of iron!—pined away. Your mother and her stepmother Battista were the same age, and both very close in age to the duke's illegitimate son **Antonio da Montefeltro Count of Cantiano**, who was, like your mother, born before the duke's first marriage. The three of them—your mother, Antonio, and the young duchess—became inseparable friends, so your mother was as much a second mother as a sister to the seven children that her father and young stepmother brought into the world: six daughters and at last one long-hoped-for son. Two of those daughters died—Aura and Girolama—but the other four—your powerful **Montefeltro aunts Giovanna, Elizabetta, Costanza, and Agnese**—all married mighty mercenaries like your father, making your grandfather Federico da Montefeltro's family the hub of a great wheel, in which all the swords-for-hire of Italy connect back through the spokes of marriage to that court in Urbino, now ruled by Federico's youngest child, the greatest mercenary now alive in Italy, your only legitimate maternal uncle **Guidobaldo da Montefeltro Duke of Urbino**. And a Wheel of Fortune is the ideal tool through which to learn the ways of politics and war.

[NOTE: Cardinal Sanseverino has a lot of important and hard-to-keep-straight family members, all core to his character; you will find a summary list at the end of the character sheet to make it easier to remember & look them up. Additionally, characters' nametags will have a red dot in the bottom right corner if you should address them as "uncle" or blue if they are "cousin" to help you remember.]

LORDS IN SWEEPING GOWNS: UNCLE GIOVANNI DELLA ROVERE DUKE OF SORA

The uncle you know best, since one of his seats of power is just a few days ride north of your home is His Grace **Giovanni della Rovere Duke of Sora and Lord of Senigallia**, nephew of Pope Sixtus, brother of **Cardinal Giuliano della Rovere**. You haven't yet met his wife in person yet, since riding is agony so you don't travel, and while mercenaries often visit many parts of Italy, their wives do not, so your **Aunt Giovanna da Montefeltro della Rovere** prefers to remain in her husband's other seat power way up in Senigallia (north of Rimini), but writes sometimes, and with fondness, to "dear Bettina's" children.

Uncle Giovanni (as His Grace lets you call him) was Pope Sixtus's nephew and chief war captains, so was often your father's direct commander, despite being forty years younger and your father's pupil in war as well as his commander (your father was Sixtus's age). Despite the differences in age and rank, these husbands of two sisters called each other 'brother' and embraced like brothers, and Uncle Giovanni often rode home with your father at war seasons' end, or stopped off on his way to or from King Ferrante's court in Naples, since your smaller castle was only a short ride from the royal seat. And after your father's death, Uncle Giovanni still came often to see his many nieces and nephews-in-law, both socially and to contract your mercenary brothers for his wars.

His Grace was as full of war stories as your father, but his were different, even as he talked of the same wars. Your father's tales were hand to hand and blow by blow, the clomps of horses' hooves, the glares of enemies, each valiant moment punctuated with a gesture and each charge a duel against some worthy foe. Uncle Giovanni's versions had a bit of that, but focused more on council chambers and commanders' tents, the bold blow not a lance but a defiant

answer given to a herald, the victory not piercing armor but persuading cities, councilors, monarchs to accept a battle plan. Uncle Giovanni says most wars are lost or won when some lord in sweeping robes decides how big a number to write on a mercenary contract, or occasionally when a pair of neighbors accept or reject a marriage bond. And when he talked of Sixtus shaping wars, or his brother, another of your uncles **Cardinal Giuliano della Rovere** (called in the family Julius, so **His Eminence Uncle Julius**) you realized they're both lords in sweeping robes, *as you will be*.

After His Grace's visits, you found yourself wanting to know what *caused* the battles that your father took his trophies from, the causes and princes behind his great campaigns. You started studying your father's career, and that way learned of the recent wars of Italy. You learned of his first service as he trained under his uncle, his mother's brother, your great uncle **Francesco Sforza** (then not yet a duke) in the service of the last **Visconti Duke of Milan**. Francesco Sforza began as nobody important but rose through repeated victories, first to be the indispensable support of the Visconti duke, then so powerful that he was feared by the Visconti duke who offered him a daughter in marriage to secure his loyalty, then ultimately overthrew the Visconti and became the self-made conqueror Duke of Milan. Sforza taking the title of duke let him give lesser titles like count to men like your father, who stayed by his ambitious uncle's side until 1452, when he undertook a courageous and fascinating pilgrimage to the Holy Land, from which he brought back many trophies, relics, a detailed diary which you've read many times, and enough Arabic to get you started—it seemed handy for a diplomatic career, so why not.

On your father's return from the Holy Land, the war climate in Italy was different: the newly-risen House of Sforza, seeking to secure itself as upstarts in a distrustful Italy where it was easier to fall than to rise, needed friends on its scale, so had made marriage alliances with the new Aragonese royal house of Naples, Duke Francesco's brilliant daughter **Ippolita Maria Sforza** to **King Ferrante of Naples's** son and heir **Crown Prince Alfonso of Naples**, with a huge dowry composed of war spoils. That connection was what let your great uncle secure your father a position as a general under King Ferrante, employed to put down the rebellions of many towns in the Kingdom of Naples which supported the old French claimants over the Aragonese conqueror. That campaign earned your father the title Count of Caiazzo and the small castle by the sea where you grew up, and most important made him famous, but the fact that a mercenary from Milan received his first fiefdom and castle in Naples was just what His Grace Uncle Giovanni said, a life path shaped by distant lords in sweeping robes, when they decided that a marriage tie would help them both. This was all still before your birth, but there was next a falling out as both King Ferrante and Duke Francesco Sforza refused to reward your father as much as he had expected for his service. He broke with both, relying on the fact that his time serving them—commissions enabled by his mother's family—had earned him enough reputation to become a spear for hire.

The next war seasons (the late 1460s) your father worked for **Piero de Medici** (father of Lorenzo the Magnificent) of Florence, which always needs to hire foreign nobles for its wars, to fight against a group of Florentine exiles who sought to overthrow the Medici, securing the aid of Venice and Ferrara by promising them chunks of eastern Tuscany. Here again it was lords in sweeping robes, the distant Doge who saw a chance for profit, merchants full of resentments, many of them sparked when Piero de Medici had married his son Lorenzo to a Roman Orsini girl, making a multi-city alliance (as the Sforza did with Naples) which his fellow Florentines felt was too princely. The general in charge of Florence's side (your father's side) of that campaign was the matchless **Federico da Montefeltro**, a man who had made himself Duke of

Urbino much as Sforza had of Milan, and it was that connection which would later result in your parents' marriage and your birth. During that campaign, your great uncle Duke Francesco Sforza died, passing Milan to his eldest son **Galeazzo Maria Sforza**, so since the uncle he had quarreled with was gone, your father returned to Sforza service. He fought several seasons' wars in Romagna in central Italy, becoming a good friend of the **Bentivoglio family of Bologna**, another powerful mercenary house, though they (like the Medici) still lack a noble title, ruling their city as "first citizen" and unofficial tyrants. They're nobles, though (unlike the Medici) but Guelphs (like the Medici). Most of those years' war seasons were shaped by small disputes among small towns as larger ones (Bologna, Urbino, Florence, Rimini) competed to dominate them, and by the ever-shifting favorites of new popes, and each war season brought your father home a *slightly* richer and more famous man, though he never rose to great wealth or to rule a city like the men he served. In one of those winters you were born, 1475.

You were too young to remember, but the next campaign your father undertook after your birth was an exceptional one, which even Uncle Giovanni (a much higher-ranking man) admired, since it took your father to the far side of the alps—a rare experience for Italian mercenaries. Galeazzo Maria Sforza, seeking to secure westward ties, married **Lady Bona of Savoy**, a cousin of the King of France, so through her your father was hired to fight for *her* father, the Duke of Savoy (the bit of southeast France closest to Italy) against the **Duke of Burgundy Charles the Bold** (since Burgundy is just north of Savoy, the region between France and Italy where Uncle Giovanni Duke of Sora's cousin **Domenico della Rovere** comes from). Lady Bona's life again taught you to think how far from battlefields victories are shaped, since she had originally been engaged to marry **King Edward IV of England**, the Yorkist claimant who overthrew Henry VI (who had been married to the daughter of the French King of Naples who had been kicked out by Ferrante's father), but rash King Edward had thrown her over for Lady Elizabeth Woodville Gray, sparking a war between France and England which nearly ended Edward's reign, and sending Lady Bona to Milan, which then shaped your father's war against Burgundy, all for the quick marriage decisions of a lustful king. Lady Bona's life is a study in fate's cruel tricks, since her first prospective husband Edward IV died and her children were overthrown and imprisoned by their uncle Richard III, while the cruel and unpopular Galeazzo Maria Sforza was butchered by assassins on his own cathedral steps and his son by Bona **Duke Gian Galeazzo Sforza** was overthrown and imprisoned by *his* brother **Ludovico Sforza, now Duke of Milan**, so both possible marriages led to her children being overthrown by her brother-in-law, and both yielded such very different wars, as far apart as England and Savoy. Your father served Lady Bona, rather than Ludovico Sforza, in their conflict, so when Duke Ludovico triumphed your father had to flee to France for a time, losing much of his wealth and land (all but your tiny plot in Naples), and was even sentenced to death in absentia. You remember that winter when he didn't come home, and you were too young to understand why there were fewer servants and your evening meals were suddenly small cold suppers instead of lavish and hot. To make things stranger, several of your older brothers were fighting *for* Ludovico in that battle, especially your third-eldest brother **Galahad "Fortunato" Sanseverino**, so some of your brothers *were actually at war with their own father and aided in his defeat!* As your father fled, and much of your family income was cut off, those same brothers became rich with the rise of Ludovico, so they started sending money home, but you remember your other siblings and your mother receiving it *very coldly*, and whispering in corners of the evening "*Traitors.*" The main traitor, your brother Galahad "Fortunato" still hasn't come home, he hasn't dared, pursuing a grand career up in Milan and occasionally writing home to see if a visit would be welcome, and your stepmother

says it's important not to directly alienate him, since the family might need him someday...

Once things cooled off with the Milan mess, he returned and fought for Genoa in one of its rebellions *against* Milan, and then fought for Pope Sixtus against Florence in the abortive effort to capture the city through the Pazzi Conspiracy, another case in which your father fought *against* Milan, where your traitor brother Galahad was becoming more and more the favorite of Duke Ludovico. Your family never did fully regain the wealth it lost from the split between your father and traitor brothers—whenever your father was victorious in a season he was often rewarded by being made lord of some small spot ruled by his employer, and had racked up a variety of little dominions near Milan or in Central Italy, which he had hoped to distribute among his sons; alas. Well, except the *traitor* sons, they're rich enough, as is the second-eldest Fracasso up in the Empire being Emperor Maximilian's jousting coach—he sends funds home, and those your family receives with a smile.

The final stages of your father's career you were old enough to remember, but discussing them anew with Uncle Giovanni they took on a different kind of sense. What had seemed to you like your father using his connections to the Sforza to organize a reconciliation between Lady Bona and his nephew Ludovico was really the process of Lady Bona being pushed out and strong allies—Pope Sixtus in his sweeping robes in Rome, King Ferrante in his sweeping robes in Naples, distant Emperor Maximilian—deciding they preferred Ludovico to Bona, and ending her power by writing on paper how many mercenary men they would supply. Your father had been one of those men, a number on a page, fighting for Sixtus, then for Innocent, for and against Florence and Venice, it was all the will of distant popes, monarchs, and cardinals—especially your famous Uncle Julius—deciding when one city's territory grew too much. Your brothers as they set out for their wars are also numbers on pieces of paper in the hands of distant courtly men. In the end, your father died for a council of such courtly men who judged which small empires needed to be pruned. Uncle Giovanni often talked about the world of politics as a garden, with different powers spreading their branches and roots, and small ambitious families or towns sprouting like weeds whose competition overstrains the soil and chokes the healthy trees.

Your father never talked like that, but hearing His Grace your uncle do so helped you finally understand the real difference between them, why your father in his glorious five decades in the field had helped so many others rise to be great rulers of cities, yet remained himself a hired sword, lord of a tiny nothing castle on the shore. How each of them told stories showed it well, your father always thinking of combat, blow-by-blow, the same perspective as a knight or rook down on the chess board facing off against the other side, but Uncle Giovanni—*His Grace Duke Giovanni*—thought like the chess player. Your father had been a tool for weeding, a trowel or a pick, a good one, but a tool still, wielded by the men with the real power who decided what to weed and when. That's why his career had helped his uncle Francesco Sforza rise to be a duke, helped your mother's father Federico da Montefeltro rise to be a duke, helped his Sforza nephews become dukes, helped his della Rovere in-laws including Uncle Giovanni become great rulers of men, while he remained a tool the used, a number written on a paper by their pens. The one time your father fought mostly for himself—the uprising against cruel King Ferrante to defend the family's feudal rights—he failed, and did attain your cardinalship, but at the cost of losing most of his wealth and lands, and seeing many kinsmen banished. Your father was too much a soldier, not a prince, and spent his long years fighting other people's battles, not his own. Your princely Uncle Giovanni only fights his own. You're a prince now too, a cardinal, a Great Prince of the Church, outranking all your brothers and your father. You're one of the lords in sweeping robes—not any of your brothers, only you. That's what His Grace the Duke of Sora

helped you see.

THE PRICE OF DIVISION: UN-WIDOW COSTANZA DA MONTEFELTRO SANSEVERINO

The aunt you know best lives strangely like a widow and a wife at once, **Costanza da Montefeltro Sanseverino**, regent and effective ruler of Salerno on behalf of her banished husband **Antonello Sanseverino Prince of Salerno**, and their young and only son **Robertino**, ten years your junior, recently turned seven. Aunt Costanza is your relative two ways, your mother's half-sister and raised with her, but also the wife of one of your father's cousins, a man more than a decade younger than your father, and who took a very different path.

In the last generation Antonello Sanseverino's father Roberto—rather to the dismay of the family and its strong Ghibelline allegiances—had married Raimonda Orsini, a princess from the family which leads the Guelph party, arch-enemies of the Caesar-advancing Ghibellines. But Antonello's father was ambitious, and Raimonda Orsini was inheretrix of the Princedom of Salerno, the second most important port in Naples, just south of the capital on the south side of the Bay of Naples instead of the north side. Thus, your uncle Antonello (though you would hesitate to address so greet a man as “uncle” if you met him) inherited a princely title, princely ambition, and stubborn Guelph pride too, especially the streak Guelphs have of refusing to acknowledge the authority of Earthly monarchy, whether the distant Emperor, or Naples's king. Antonello was and is a warrior and skilled naval commander, and served for a time as Admiral for King Ferrante of Naples, but he began to quarrel with the king over his rights, especially when the king denied his ancient princely privilege to have his own private Militia as Prince of Salerno. When you were ten, Antonello became one of the chief agitators in the War of the Conspiracy of the Barons, leading a number of disgruntled lords allied with the Orsini, Pope Innocent, and the House of della Rovere (including Uncle Giovanni della Rovere and Uncle Julius) to make war on Naples and overthrow the king. Your father, the most veteran commander in the southern half of Naples, led the papal armies in the war, but King Ferrante of Naples was a cunning man, luring some of your family's allies to his side with promises of compromise and reconciliation, and then using the war plans they shared with him in trust to cut off your father's and family's armies before they could strike. The king's cruel cunning won the day, slaughtering or arresting most who opposed him, confiscating many lands (including many of your father's), and forever stripping almost all the feudal rights of all the lower houses within Naples. Your father was eventually forgiven, since he had been a mercenary fighting for the pope rather than *directly* in rebellion against the king, while your uncle Antonello had to flee France (disguising himself as a mule-herd to escape the king's assassins). He's still in exile in France, at King Charles's court, and given his hatred of the current Kin of Naples he is likely urging Charles on to press his claim to Naples and invade.

A rebel leader's wife and son might be in danger from an angry king, were Aunt Costanza not the woman that she is, but the daughter of Duke Federico da Montefeltro and Battista Sforza was as ready to take to the battlements as her celebrated niece Caterina. Thus, for almost ten years, Aunt Costanza has ruled Salerno, setting to rest all who would suspect her of conspiring with her husband through her shocking candor, discoursing at every dinner upon the many strategic errors her husband made in his ill-fated war, and how she has sworn an oath not to oppose the king in return for her son retaining the family's lands, but had *she* been in command during the rebellion *she* would have *seen it through*, by never trusting A, taking more troops to B, launching night raids at C, etc. She talks more like a general than the generals

you've met, her spirit such a fine match for your father's that you're sure she is much of the model for the memories of your mother in your mind. Her boldness impresses everyone, even the king, whom you have heard laugh, saying that if Montefeltro's daughter wore the britches in Salerno he might not be king today, but that a woman so martial and so honest is no liar when she says she will stay faithful to her oath of fealty even if her traitor husband marches to her gates, they will stay barred. Amazing woman.

You wish you knew Aunt Costanza better. Many of your siblings were fostered, either long-term or for one year at a time, at Aunt Costanza's court (no sense in raising twenty children in the smaller family castle with just one kid in the bigger one just down the road) and when you were very small you went with your whole family to Salerno every year for Easter and for Michaelmas, while she and her husband, would come to you for Pentecost and Christmas, but now that you can't ride you stay home when the others go, and only get to see her twice a year, and when you do, with so many siblings competing for attentions from this queenly storyteller, you don't often have the energy to be up front. Now though, you wish you'd pushed more, asked her more. You're setting out, a novice to real politics, to navigate one of these huge tangles of politics that she knows inside out—it's one of the seats of Orsini power for goodness sake!—you're sure you'll make mistakes. How did Aunt Costanza manage to navigate keeping the Princedom of Salerno for herself and her small son while her husband was being chased out as a traitor, and so many of his peers stripped of their office? How can she rattle off so perfectly the points at which her husband made mistakes, should have backed down, or not back down? She thinks like a chess player, like Uncle Giuliano encouraged you to think.

THE COURT OF MADNESS: OLIVIERO CARAFA & FABRIZIO COLONNA

Two more uncles-in-law helped you to understand that the world of men in sweeping robes, the one you're entering, can hold as deadly terrors as the battlefield. You met them both in Naples. **Cardinal Oliviero Carafa** comes from one of the greatest houses of Naples, a relative of Thomas Aquinas, and an uncle through your half-sister Giulia who married his nephew Giovanni Tomasso Carafa. **Duke Fabrizio Colonna, Grand Constable of Naples**, is one of the mightiest sons of the house that leads the great Ghibelline party, and the husband of one of your mother Bettina's half-sisters, **Agnese da Montefeltro**.

Both His Eminence **Uncle Carafa** and His Grace **Uncle Fabrizio** you got to know through spending some summers at the court of His Majesty **King Ferrante of Naples**, overlord of the little castle you called home, and your father's sometimes-employer. Your eldest brothers had often been called to court in summers, and after your cardinalship was secure you started being asked to come along, not yet understanding that, as a future cardinal, you meant more to the crown of Naples than your dozen mercenary brothers—while they courted the king for future jobs, the king was courting you. Or his courtiers were, at least, Naples' nobility eager to make a friend of one who would soon have a voice in Rome, where the decisions made by Princes of the Church have so much power over many lives. Your uncles were already among the greatest men at the court—His Grace Uncle Fabrizio as Grand Constable commanded and hired all the soldiers and police for the whole kingdom, while Uncle Carafa was the king's right hand and mightiest adviser, the first voice to bring issues to the court, often the last adviser whom the king called on before judgment, and the only man apart from King Ferrante's son and heir Crown Prince Alfonso who had permission to sign documents as the king's proxy. Your arrival, and the whispers, "A second cardinal for Naples at last!" made them stand like giants among their peers,

while they in turn, strong allies, were the living promises of loyalty which let your brothers, despite their fathers' opposition to Ferrante in the rebellion, come to court.

The castle at the city's heart, facing the azure bay, was straight out of an epic of King Arthur: pennants flapping, minstrels, tumblers, jousts in their flashing armor, the spectators in garish houppelandes, bright in the colors of their coats of arms, their hems dagged like the boxy crenellations of the battlements, and in the galleries the lines of fair damsels beneath their silken veils. And there were combat sports and blood sports: show duels, wrestling, bear baiting, cockerel fighting, hounds against captured wild boars, hounds against lions, hounds against criminals from the royal dungeons (the criminals never won). Those blood sports should have told you sooner that something was rotten in Ferrante's court.

One uncle or the other always escorted your visits, hovering as close as nursemaids, not just within sight but within reach. His Grace Uncle Fabrizio was stunning from the first, his huge, ribbony sleeves of white and scarlet, his etched armor sparkling, far too much showmanship and poise for you to spot wariness underneath. Not so His Eminence Uncle Carafa—the first time you saw him you thought he was ill, he looked so unsteady in his movement, and his skin had something off about its under-color, grayish, like when your stepmother's old nursemaid Claudia was dying of pneumonia, or your short-lived little brother Stefano in his last weeks. But that color isn't illness. You saw it in others too, soon, in the captain of the royal guard, the seneschal, master of the revels, in the secretaries, royal tutors, couriers, valets, even, beneath that flashing helmet, in Uncle Fabrizio, in everyone whose daily duties kept them near Scylla—that's what, behind his back, they call the king.

Charybdis is the kind of monster with one giant mouth that swallows the whole ship, like conquest or a civil war (Naples has seen a lot of those in living memory), while Scylla is a monster with six heads that, as each ship goes by, snatches and eats six men, but only six, a tithe paid to rapacious evil but the rest survive. Smart captains accept such risks and have their crew keep to the Scylla side, and so with King Ferrante. He seems to have a certain quota of suspicions energy that needs to vent on something, so every few days his paranoia needs a new victim. It can be real threats like criminals or spies brought in for sentencing, or news of distant towns or barons making allies of his enemies and possibly preparing to rebel, but if too few of those crop up then it will be someone he spots walking round the castle in a way he finds suspicious, or who leaves the chamber once too often during a royal audience, or doesn't clap enough or claps too much watching the games. Suspicion usually grows into the king having the suspect watched, then tested in some weird way, like having all the clothing in their chambers replaced with some wildly inappropriate clothing, or having little barbed iron caltrops put in their roast meat at dinner to see how they react. No matter what their reaction, it always confirms the king's suspicions, and the next step is the sudden arrest, usually in the dead of night, then interrogations, and either a confession and execution or, if some *real* object for suspicion has come along, the king sometimes forgets about them in his dungeons for some months until (in lucky cases) ministers release them on the quiet. Half the time there seems to be no logic to the target, but just as often there is some reason the king would want to pressure that person or family—suddenly offering a baron's son a tour of his torture chambers when the baron is protesting a tax increase. Sometimes the king's advisers, or his son Crown Prince Alfonso point him toward particular targets (and you understand that, on his own, the prince himself does crueler things with women of the court, and even bullied his first wife to death). Ferrante's weekly victim can be anybody, high or low, but not *too* high, there are a *few* people who either have powerful friends—like Ferrante's current wife **Queen Joana d'Aragona**, sister of

Ferdinand of Aragon—or irreplaceable uses, like His Eminence Uncle Carafa. Or you. That was the strangest part, when you stood with your brothers in the court. They're fair game, the dozen mercenary sons of one old count, but even King Ferrante doesn't dare kill cardinals, if you or your uncle Carafa died, your cardinalships wouldn't pass to others in Naples, they'd simply go away, leaving the kingdom weakened by losing its voices at the Vatican.

So, week after week, Uncle Carafa and Uncle Fabrizio stand beside Scylla, trying as they can to sate the monster's appetite with criminals and real traitors, yet knowing every tiny failure, even chitchat taken the wrong way, could redirect the vicious heads against the innocent, or, worse, against his kin. That's why your uncles kept you ever within reach, like mother geese, on hand to stress to the forgetful king, "Young Messer Federico will soon be a cardinal," whenever suspicious royal eyes fell upon you. Your brothers too they looked out for, letting only a couple of them at a time be called to court, sending them home or off to train when they received too much attention, or if someone reminded King Ferrante that there were still rebellious Sanseverinos off in France desiring his ruin. The scariest moment was during a visit from another uncle, the only time you met him, Count Antonio da Montefeltro, the illegitimate half-brother sired, like your mother, before Duke Federico's first marriage. Count Antonio is a masterful soldier and a veteran of many campaigns, but not a ruler, just a trusted servant of his legitimate younger brother Duke Guidobaldo, so when he caught the suspicions of the king it progressed as far as a midnight arrest and a round of torture before Uncle Carafa and Uncle Fabrizio's joint campaign of bribery, exoneration, and distraction barely managed to get the man—a duke's brother!—out of Naples alive. That helped you understand why Uncle Carafa seemed so much more harried than Uncle Fabrizio. The powerful Colonna family has its seat in Rome, so Fabrizio often gets to leave Naples to strengthen that connection, and has kept his wife and family there, safely far from King Ferrante's reach; not so His Eminence Carafa whose family are all in Naples, and could at any moment be the next to be offered a friendly tour of the castle's dungeon layer.

While you never became very close with His Eminence Uncle Carafa or His Grace Uncle Fabrizio, never sat long hours at their sides discussing histories like with Uncle Giovanni della Rovere, by watching them you got to learn a new side of those lords in sweeping robes who dictate wars and victories by writing numbers on a piece of paper: some of them are prudent, cunning calculators, fighting their own wars like Uncle Giovanni and his brother Uncle Julius. But some of them wield their pens as recklessly as children playing with a grown man's sword, and just as many battles in this world are ruled by them. No wonder Uncle Giovanni prides himself on *not* fighting other men's wars. And no wonder so many of the wars your father fought made little sense, re-bloodying the same just-bloodied ground for some new pretext, factions switching and betraying over tiny slights or dusty parchments claiming someone had an old right to a pointless salt tax, or a mill stream whose profits weren't worth a hundredth of the cost of war, but made a great excuse. You asked Uncle Fabrizio how he feels about fighting other men's wars—in His Grace's case fighting King Ferrante's wars—but he answered that as the leaders of the Ghibelline party, the Colonna House are the custodians of all of Italy, so a Colonna never fights other men's wars, other men—even great kings—are actually fighting theirs. His Grace sounded a bit like your Uncle Giovanni then, the confidence of a man who felt he fought wars on the scale of Caesars, and used the small wars of rash kings like Ferrante to help prune Italy. But your father had been a Ghibelline champion too, and did his wars really feel like they advanced a Caesar?

EXTREMES OF LIBERTY: THE MERRY MALATESTA WIDOWS

Two other uncles, **Roberto and Carlo Malatesta**, you know only through tales and letters, the dead husbands of two more of your mother's half-sisters, the "merry widows of the House of Malatesta" as they call themselves, your **Aunts Gentile and Elizabetta da Montefeltro** (the latter being the reason your mother goes by the nickname "Bettina" to avoid confusion with the other Elizabetta da Montefeltro).

The House of Malatesta are another mercenary house, who made themselves the masters of the port city of Rimini, as the Sforza did of Milan and the Montefeltros of Urbino. Rimini is smaller and less powerful than Milan or Urbino (a lordship, not a duchy), smaller even than Salerno, yet mighty compared with your father's small patch, even if your father's title "Marquis" was technically higher (titles often don't match to real power, you only need to look at Bologna or Florence to know that). Your Malatesta uncles are both dead—one of battle wounds, the other of an illness caught while on the march—and their widows Gentile and Elizabetta returned to the family seat of Urbino, but send letters, the distant voices and holiday wishes women who knew and loved your mother, and care deeply about your side of the family, although *not* about their wild husbands' side. The Malatesta are ferocious warriors and strong allies, true, with many battles and more wealth and territory to their name than your father's, but they are also... it's hard to express... a world, and law, and way unto themselves.

Accounts tell of the Malatesta riding into battle, not shouting like men, but shrieking like wild birds of prey, laughing like mockingbirds, howling like wolves. They bring enemies down with strange contraptions, putting spiked armor on their horses' legs to slash at other horses, and wielding thick blades triangular in cross-section, so that the wounds they make can't close, and even those who face their blades who might normally live are guaranteed a cruel, lingering death. They loot and sack, always, even when towns surrender, even though your father says that's stupid and will make small towns resist that would surrender easily. They don't hesitate to give even their noble captives welts and bruises and rough dunkings into muddy pits, and when they take towns they don't just carry off choice courtiers like the tutors, craftsmen, and entertainers that father brought home, they carry off the nuns. And they betray. All sides, all families. Your uncle Roberto Malatesta's father Sigismundo was so wild and betrayed Pope Pius II (Piccolomini) so many times that the pope invented a new ceremony to have Sigismundo *canonized into Hell*, he hated him so much. And worse than that, Malatestas betray even each other. It's not that rare—Sforzas betray Sforzas, your brothers fought your father, and your father and his cousin Aunt Costanza's husband Antonello fought each other too—but Malatestas betray Malatestas *viciously* and *frequently*. That's why your grandfather Francesco da Montefeltro married *two* of his daughters to Malatestas, not just one, the family had split into two branches leading wars against each other, and your grandfather gave daughters to both, both to befriend, and to reconcile them.

And the Malatestas are pagans. They really are, your aunts are candid in their letters. Oh, plenty of people fling the slur of paganism against those who are enthusiastic about Latin and Greek classics and who collect ancient statues and seek wisdom in the secrets of the ancient mystics, but your Montefeltro aunts were reading Cicero composing Latin when they were five, when *they* say that the Malatestas are *real pagans* they are serious. You've seen their letters, filled with wonder and derision, writing of how Rimini's... well, no one calls it a "cathedral" they just say "the Malatesta Temple" since it's dedicated to the "Holy Spirit" and hardly has any hint of Christ in it at all, a pagan temple, basically to *Sol Invictus*, the Unconquered Sun, with

paintings of the stars and planets, Greek and Roman symbols, pagan gods, Helios in his chariot, no saints, just all the trappings of the ancient solar cult. A cult! That's what it is! As pagan as the cults of Mithras or Osiris, cults that even Seneca and Cicero were wise enough to mock, small-minded men seeing a brightness in the sky and not realizing it is just the image of a far higher greatness which makes the power to turn night to day seem tiny as a candle. They take pride in it, the Malatestas, bring ambassadors and dignitaries to that church to watch their jaws drop as the masters of the city revel in the fact that nobody can stop them. No one *dares*. The popes have three times taken Rimini away from them in the last thirty years, but every time the Malatesta take it back with so much treachery and blood—Uncle Roberto disguised himself as a farmer to sneak in and then seize it by force—that even popes give up. The cult of *Sol Invictus* is the Malatesta's thumb in the eye of all authority, defiant proof that with sufficient force and fortifications not all the powers of all calm men in the world can root out men who will resort to every dirty trick, and repay every act of trust or generosity with bestial howls and violent banditry. It works.

The merry widows, as your Aunts Gentile and Elizabetta call themselves, are glad to have been able to make peace between Urbino and the Malatestas, since Rimini and their other seats of power are so uncomfortably close to Urbino. The peace was wisely bought and well-maintained, but **Aunt Gentile**—whose husband Carlo came from the more rebellious branch—was in no way sad to be widowed quickly, and remarried to a more sensible mercenary, **Agostino Fregoso of Genoa**, who also died in battle but gave her eight children, the elder of whom are doing well in Genoa, the youngest three still growing up in Urbino. Aunt Gentile is forty-four years old, and, like your mother, an earlier illegitimate daughter from before your grandfather's marriage, but as welcome and loved by the family as her half-sisters. Aunt Gentile has a cousin-in-law in Rome, **Cardinal Paolo Campofregoso**, who is thus yet another of your many relatives, though you have never interacted, and you're a bit wary of him. The Fregoso or Campofregoso family (they use both forms of the name) were for a long time the most powerful family in Genoa, and had a virtual monopoly on the office of Doge of Genoa for decades (an elected non-hereditary monarchy, think President for life) rivaled only by the Adorno family (who has the Dogeship now), but the (Campo)Fregosos were constantly undone by *foolishly betraying each other* (rather like the Malatesta). If you look at the list of Doges of Genoa you often see (Campo)Fregoso brothers or cousins overthrowing each other and stealing the office back and forth. This particular Campofregoso was three times Doge of Genoa, which means he was overthrown three times, and the cousin he was struggling with over the crown is the father of Aunt Gentile's husband Agostino, i.e. this exiled Cardinal Campofregoso is an *enemy* of the Fregoso branch your aunt married into. And he seems like a rough character: he was rumored to be a pirate for a while (which is how he garnered naval skills, and at one point led the defensive navy to drive the Ottoman invaders back out of Otranto), but the third time he was kicked out of being Doge it wasn't another Fregoso, it was a council of elders who decided it was better to *submit to the domination of Sforza conquerors than be under this guy!* You know him by reputation only but it isn't a good reputation (although a bishop with a career as a pirate sounds neat? He also personally led armies against France once, when they were driven out of Genoa in the 1440s.) You don't know whether this strange cousin will be wild in the fun way or wild in the dangerous way, but he's definitely a kinsman to be approached with caution.

Aunt Elizabetta, the other Merry Malatesta Widow, is only twenty-eight and had a rougher path but bore it out with dignity, since there was no rapport at all between the refined Urbanese princess and the howling Malatesta beast. She spent her years in Rimini as aloof and

cold as a statue of Athene, a pillar of sanity to whom embassies clung amid the Malatesta madness, as Roberto Malatesta paraded favorite mistresses through his court and doted on his many bastards. She says she smiled when she heard she'd died in a swampy pit like the beast he was, and returned very content after six years of frustrating marriage to join a convent of Poor Clares (basically female Franciscans) in Urbino, alternating between the cloister's peace and her brother's glorious court (Poor Clares are usually cloistered i.e. don't go out, but no one is going to stop the duke's sister from visiting her brother when she likes).

The Malatestas are still out there, up in Rimini and hired out each war season, and as kinsmen they write to you as well, their letters and those of the happy widows good reminders of how strange the fringes of the world can be. The most extreme extreme of liberty, that's what Aunt Elizabetta calls it, the furthest limit to which men can push away from the ancient and divine law that there must be some order in the world. Push far enough from that, by fire and steel, and you become so ungovernable, so incomprehensible, that the political world doesn't know how to deal with you, and leaves you to yourself. It keeps them in power, mad as it is to call madness a strategy, but your Uncle Giovanni points out that, if it is a strategy, it has its limits. Malatesta power is entrenched in Rimini and *stays in Rimini*, and every effort to expand beyond has been stomped out by the coordinated efforts of all civilized men of Italy. So poisonous a stinging bramble will be purged with fire if it tries to spread, though—as Uncle Giovanni says—it will take a very daring gardener to venture close enough to get the root. And then he smiles: “Perhaps it will be you or me.”

The Malatestas are your most distant relations in some sense—none of them share your blood except back several generations—but the bonds are there, and now that you are taking up your place in Rome you know they will start writing to you for the things they need that only Rome can give. The Malatestas are so strange about religion that they are the only major mercenary house in Italy (the only noble house of any kind!) that sends *no* sons into the Church. Not one. They didn't even bother to send a nephew to become bishop of their cathedral, they just signed it over to your Uncle Carafa to be titular bishop and collect the rents in return for his promise as a kinsman that he would leave the Malatesta Temple to the Unconquered Sun alone. There aren't a lot of things a family like the Malatestas need from you at the Vatican, but they do need a sane man to represent their family as they seek marriage alliances and new commissions for the coming mercenary season, and the closest thing to a sane relative they have in Rome is you.

Do you want to help the Malatestas? You would have said *no* two years ago—you might have said no to a lot of things you're now starting to do in Rome, if not for one last influence, the uncle you have met the fewest times of those you know, and yet in many ways the one who matters most of all. And as for the (Campo)Fregosos of Genoa, kinsmen or no it seems like it's better for you and everyone if Genoa stays safely under the rule of your stabler Sforza kinsmen (though with so many Sforzas betraying Sforzas it's really something to say that they're *more stable* than the (Campo)Fregosos!)

But there are more stable parts of your extended family tree that you *do* want to help...

THE HUB OF FORTUNE'S WHEEL: UNCLE GUIDOBALDO DA MONTEFELTRO

You knew His Grace by gifts first, sent to your family every winter as reminder that one node within the web of aunts and uncles that surrounds you is a power on a very different scale. They came after the new year, commissioned by the duke when he returned from each war season,

varying in splendor with the scale of his successes that campaign. One year it was bolts of Florentine brocade and fine Genoese velvet, another newfangled printed books from Venice, another year a hundred peacocks, colored and albino, whose descendants still swarm gorgeously across your fields. Another year he sent three dozen different kinds of bows, from massive English longbows, to serpentine Turkish recurves, to some so cunningly designed that even a girl of six could draw one comfortably. He always sent the same to all the children, grown and tiny, boys and girls, his sister's children and those with no Montefeltro blood treated the same, all except, after your injuries, for you. The year he sent everyone hawks and hounds for hunting, he sent you two breeding pairs of each, and manuals on how to breed and train them. The very profitable year that he sent all your siblings splendid white horses from the Caucuses you were braced for a donkey (traditional for priests), but instead His Grace sent you three horses and a chariot designed after Homer's description of Achilles's, and with its seat padded so cunningly that, in it, you can endure several miles' drive (*enough to go hunting! You love hunting!*). And when your father died, and the banishment of treacherous Antonello Prince of Salerno ended all your family's hopes of being more than a forgotten side branch of a disgraced noble house, Duke Guidobaldo's gifts began to come three times a year.

In letters—it was usually your stepmother who got them—His Grace was frank yet grand, using the royal *we* as a reminder that, unlike subject dukes like Uncle Giovanni Duke of Sora who must answer to a king, as lord of Urbino up in the Papal States (or “Roman States” as he calls them) His Grace, equal with kings, answers only to Caesar. His letters always address your stepmother as “sister” and put family first, filled with congratulations “We were glad to hear our niece Eleonora's Pentecost oration much praised by our sister Costanza,” and invitations, “We should welcome any more nephews or nieces who would join our court.” These pleasantries would then give way to a chillingly candid run-down of exactly which wars were brewing for the next months, which mercenaries (friend and foe alike) were hired where, and firm advice about what offers your brothers old enough to go to war should take or shun. This frank talk of the work of war—including estimates of how many thousands had just died or were about to die, and very *colorful* criticism of those the duke judged fools—are certainly what one expects of a man who first commanded of the League of Papal Armies at the age of eleven (!!!) and now, though only twenty, is already veteran of ten campaigns. But in letters his hardened war words always veer surreally into ending sweetly with “Our Elizabetta sends her love...” and some final comment on what artworks or Latin manuscripts his beloved duchess **Elizabetta Gonzaga** was working on.

Duchess Elizabetta Gonzaga is another of these learned wonder women, the sister of Duke Guidobaldo's brother-in-law and **favorite war partner Francesco Gonzaga Marquess of Mantua**, through whose influence the duchess is as fluent in war as in her many languages, with the expertise to pronounce on the merits of a Greek adverb, a marble relief, and a siege engine with equal expertise. Urbino's court is such a nexus of artists and scholars—some brought there by stories of splendor, others by the duke as spoils from his wars, that half your stepmother's correspondence is contacts asking if she might help persuade the duke to lend them an artist or an orator, or invite aspiring sons or daughters to his court. Duchess Elizabetta is (unusually) eight years *older* than her husband Duke Guidobaldo, but the two are as famously devoted a couple as the last generation of Urbino's rulers, and while you have never met her, you know you have met her echo many times, since, not just your sisters, but every lady at every court, even in royal Naples, aspires to imitate her in fashion, style, studies, and dignity, a lady rivaled as the queen of courtly fashions only by Isabella and Beatrice d'Este of the unrivaled ruling family of Ferrara.

You have met His Grace your uncle Guidobaldo (though ‘uncle’ feels weird with him, since he’s barely older than you are). All three encounters were life-changing.

You were just ten years old the first time your warlike uncle graced your humble family castle with a visit. He was everything you could no longer be, barely fourteen—more like another brother than an uncle—yet already a veteran and famed commander, stunning on horseback with a commanding gaze and hair still slightly child-blond, much like the boy king Arthur might have seemed. Duke Guidobaldo had commanded armies at eleven, when he inherited his father’s last commission, Commander General of the armies Milan and Naples, which Federico da Montefeltro had been leading against Venetian troops under his son-in-law Roberto Malatesta when, in the marshes near Ferrara, malaria, not battle, claimed them both. Now at fourteen he had already completed two campaigns as Commander of the Papal Armies, and now—in the third—was leading his armies down into Naples to rescue papal troops cornered through King Ferrante’s cunning traps. The visit was two nights, a stop-off between battles. The duke spent half the day on letters and dispatches, dictating one message to his scribes while writing out another with his hand, but he did join you and your brothers for your exercise, swimming—you couldn’t believe it—in his gambeson and chainmail shirt, fighting the extreme weight and currents with his war-slim arms, saying he’d seen enough men drown in their armor in rivers and marshes to know that a soldier should pass up no chance to practice for that side of war. You didn’t know the real reason until years later.

At the evening meal your mother seated Duke Guidobaldo at the head of the table and he and the (much older) captains who came with him invited questions about their wars. His men spoke much more than he did, meeting each question with a thrilling anecdote or dash of expertise, often testing your more mature brothers by challenging them to suggest what they would do in such a situation before revealing their own escapades. His Grace spoke sparingly, twice to cut short tales that had meandered on too long and redirect the conversation back to the real question, and several times to praise opponents, pointing out moments of prudence, strength, or honor showed by enemies, rebalancing the war to feel like one of excellence on excellence when his subordinates focused too much on their own valor. In speech the duke slips seamlessly between the ducal ‘we’ and the personal ‘I’ as his discourse snakes between his judgments as a sovereign, and his more speculative thoughts as just a man.

In the dark and quiet after the long evening meal wound up, you went out to the little fire-heated warehouse behind the castle where the gardeners put the potted citrus trees for winter, where you like to lie and stretch on the warm stones to work the pain out as you get ready for bed, and you were surprised to find Duke Guidobaldo there alone, reading Livy. You tried to apologize, excuse yourself, but he asked your opinion on Flaminius at the Battle of Lake Trasimene, and drew you into a long discussion of Hannibal’s campaigns, which you remember enjoying but also feeling pressured—you wish you could remember better, but it’s only fragments, and an image of the fire’s flicker awakening a rusty color as it backlit the black velvet of his sleeve. By morning he was gone, back to his wars as if Mars visited in secret the way Eros does, but his copy of Livy was still there, with the duke’s own notes inside, waiting for you, and with it your stepmother’s question, “Did His Grace find you?” That’s when you realized it was no coincidence, the long grilling on Livy in the lemon house. Your father had told Duke Guidobaldo that you were to be a cardinal, and His Grace had come to see what kind of child you were who would grow up to wield the family’s power within the Church—the crosier to partner his sword.

The second time was five years later, 1490, just two years ago. You had turned fifteen,

Duke Guidobaldo was about to be nineteen—the gap in years was still the same but he had seemed so big and grown before, and seemed much closer to you then. You saw him at the court of Naples. **King Matthias Corvinus of Hungary** had just died, widowing Ferrante's daughter Queen Beatrice, a daughter of Ferrante of Naples, so many parties moved between Naples and other parts of Italy, Duke Guidobaldo among them, though when attending on the king there were not many chances to see him in private. Your brothers saw him more. He show-dueled Crown Prince Alfonso (and won) and several of Ferrante's favorite champions (a respectable mixture of victories and defeats), and the morning of the match invited your brothers to exercise with him, testing their swordplay and wordplay (you got to watch), and invited them to Urbino to serve under him if they wished, encouraging them to bring some of your sisters too, to join the duchess for education in the arts of court as he trained them in arts of war. You remember one dinner when the king was off doing something, so Prince Alfonso (a little spiteful after his defeat) headed up the table and turned the talk to war and honor, implying that his loss had come about because Duke Guidobaldo 'like most swords for hire' had picked up 'dishonorable tricks.' His Grace the duke spoke little and strategically, mostly praising opponents he had faced upon war's honorable field. You don't remember who asked it directly: how can a mercenary balance honor with his calling? Where is honor when Duke Guidobaldo and his father had both battled their own kinsmen—like Roberto Malatesta—for a bag of gold? You kept quiet, but found yourself brooding on how your brothers may well die, if not for the duke, then at his hand. His Grace was... evasive is too strong, he made it look like elegance, speaking mainly to invite others to weigh in, and listening attentively to all both high and low, just as the manuals of courtly etiquette dictate he should. He even asked *you* what *you* thought.

That put you on the spot. You are a priest, a spectator to such a conversation, but the prince and everyone was staring at you, so you dredged up something you remembered Uncle Giovanni della Rovere saying: that fools say there are two kinds of men in the world, loyal ones who stay true to their friends, and mercenary ones who shed all causes and all faith water off a duck's back, but—and you did credit Uncle Giovanni with the observation—if there really are two kinds of men in the world, it's the fools who think that joining anything must be forever, and those wise enough to understand that some ties are for life, others short-term ties for convenience, and that the same man can have both so long as he makes them clear. Your father—you added—and the duke's father His Grace Federico da Montefeltro, had both been willing to take commissions *for* the Medici of Florence one season and to take Sixtus's commission to attack the Medici the next, and both even took Guelph pay sometimes and battled fellow Ghibellines, but when the party truly needed them and called them (you raised your glass toward your Uncle Fabrizio Colonna who sat between Duke Guidobaldo and the prince) they would not fail. The answer seemed to satisfy, though you're not the best at reading dinner table glances and were worried, among the dozens of dignitaries whom you struggled to keep straight, that you might have accidentally brought up something that offended somebody—remember who took what side in what old war is as impossible as it is essential. The talk moved on, Uncle Fabrizio and others agreeing, commenting, but you noticed His Highness Prince Alfonso kept pointing questions at the duke, phrasing them strangely, asking what His Grace thought was more important, potency or honor, whether there could be potency without honor, or honor without potency, and then you remembered the story that had circulated recently, that after several childless years of marriage some had started pressuring Duke Guidobaldo to divorce his barren duchess, and that the duke had stunned them by announcing publicly the truth most men would be far too ashamed to speak, that it was him, not her. When the prince grew tired of

making a game of it he directly: “Has Your Grace of Urbino nothing to say about honor? Cat got your... (pointed silence)... tongue?” You remember His Grace’s answer verbatim:

“The god of war—Homer says—is impartial, he hands out death to the man who hands out death. When bought, I am the god of war. Victorious Minerva, on the other hand, is partiality itself, guarding her friends with every tool from guile to her Father’s thunder, and those who offend her know no end but massacre. My honor is that, if the man who guarded my back for gold yesterday, for more gold sends me to my grave tomorrow, I shall bear no grudge, but His Eminence my godfather Piccolomini once saved our father’s life for kindness and for justice, not for gold, so we shall guard him with our force and fortunes to the world’s end, and whosoever threatens him shall find in us no bought, impartial Mars, but an implacable Minerva.”

You wondered afterward whether he’d had such a perfect reply prepared in advance, or whether he’d just been working on it through the conversation. You never dreamed you’d have the chance to *ask*, but afterward, impossible by moonlight, there he was on the roof terrace of Uncle Carafa’s suite, where you like to stroll and stretch at bedtime, sitting on the pale stone rail with his legs hanging recklessly over the long plunge to the waves below. He didn’t bother starting with hello. “I remind men of my debt of honor to Piccolomini every chance I have, so, knowing me so strict about a debt that isn’t even from my own lifetime, men never doubt that all my actions must be shaped by equally rigid honor. Thanks to that, no client doubts my word or actions, even when they should, and when I do switch sides in war, the very men I have betrayed don’t doubt I did it for some bond of honor, so they bear no grudge when I do what I will. Reputation is sounder armor than steel.”

It flustered you, this sudden candid answer to the question you hadn’t dared ask. You did dare ask, “Why did you tell me that, Your Grace?”

“We want the partner at our back to know us well. You know, Father Sanseverino, that we have no brother at our side to take the cloth. Most of our sisters have few sons, and need them all as heirs and blades. His Eminence Carafa is an old man, our godfather Piccolomini too. Our family web may stretch to every shore of Italy, but the only man who can hold the end in Rome as long and steadily as we shall hold Urbino’s is yourself.” He tossed you a small packet. “Letters from your stepmother and family.”

You gaped. You knew that handwriting. That he’d stopped off at your home, *your small, backwater home*, before coming to Naples. Duke Guidobaldo wasn’t there to see the king—he came for you. So you stayed up together until dawn brightened the sky, talking of things you curse at not remembering better. Sometimes it still feels like that night by starlight was some faerie prince’s visitation in a dream. You do remember one moment, toward the end. “You didn’t give the prince a real answer. You said what His Grace the Duke of Sora says of mercenary honor, but what does Abbot Sanseverino think?”

You frowned. “I don’t have my own opinion, I’m not a soldier.”

“Then how will you protect the honor of the men you sell in Rome, when every sword for hire in our family writes to you?”

The third encounter was less five months ago. Pope Innocent was dying. You were in a kind of stupor, stunned and panicking inside, as your stepmother joined by Aunt Costanza had the castle buzzing with a thousand preparations for your elevation and your move to Rome. At their insistence you’d put on your sweeping Benedictine robe at last. It felt strange, the way your motions were so different, every gesture of its loose sleeve rippling down the whole great waterfall of cloth, musty and drafty like old curtains or a shroud. You didn’t feel like you. Robes also changed the rhythm of your spine’s pain, as you moved a little differently, without the

tautness of your doublet and the tight-laced waistband of your slops, which you hadn't realized had been supporting something in your lower back. You couldn't make yourself think about Rome. Letters were trickling in from every distant cousin, from Colonnas, (Campo)Fregosos, Carafas, Malatestas, from lieutenants of your distant elder brothers and from sons and daughters of soldiers who fought for your late father or grandfather before you were born—all need things from Rome. You'd been preparing for almost eight years but it still felt unreal, as if your father might come in at any moment to announce he'd changed his mind. You found yourself retreating to your long swims and your room, and your stepmother was pretending not to fret about it. Then his letter came. You'd exchanged many in the intervening year, long ones from him commenting on his wars and court encounters, which you tried to match with observations from your visits to Naples, though it always felt like offering a single apple to a man who'd sent a feast. This one was different: *"Guidobaldo master of Urbino to our dear nephew Abbot Federico Sanseverino, greetings. We are taking the waters on Ischia. Join us."*

No such summons could be refused, even if he'd summoned you to trek through days of to Urbino, but Ischia was mercifully easy, a volcanic island famous for its healing hot springs, and an easy day's sail from your seaside home (smooth waves not bouncy roads!). He'd taken the finest villa on the island, with the steam from the volcanic hot springs snaking up, so it really did look like the dragon Typhon was trapped under there by Jupiter, as the ancients say. You wondered if he picked the venue just for you, until after the welcome meal when you went together to the private spring, and you saw how he grunted with the strain of pulling off his boots, and how his shoes peeled back to bear feet scarred and blistered, toes discolored by too many hours in the saddle or the mire. He knows pain too.

"Do you know what you and the other cardinals will do in Rome?" He asked it bluntly.

"We're going to make a pope," you answered, smiling, but his eyes didn't smile back. You frowned. "I guess Your Grace would say we're going to make a war."

His nod was interrupted by a little wince, as he worked to undo the lacing of his sleeves, making you notice that his finger joints were subtly red and swollen too. Strain? Gout? Both? You remember feeling lucky that your feet and hands are fine, and that your Benedictine habit has at least the merit of simplicity.

"This war season will be different," he said. "The king of France thinks he can glut himself on Italy like a fox in a henhouse, and if we quarreling cockerels don't all have our spurs on ready and our quarrels put aside, he may be right. New pope may round us up into a league, or set us at each other's throats, or help the French, or sit there like a log."

You smiled realizing your winces matched the duke's as you unlaced the back brace you now wear under your robes. "You expect me to be able to influence which pope gets picked? I'm not a kingmaker, Your Grace, I'll be the newest, youngest cardinal."

"No. I, and every hired sword which calls you kinsman, just expect you to tell us which side to sell our spears to this time. I want the fox out of the henhouse, but I'll fight for Charles if it means he spares our section of the henhouse, better than lose it all."

You jumped in, eager to let the water's heat and healing powers leach the pain away. "You should ask experienced men, Your Grace, like Uncle Carafa, or Uncle Julius, or Cardinal Colonna, or Cardinal Sforza."

He shook his head as he counted on his fingers. "Carafa's under King Ferdinand's thumb, della Rovere's under Charles's, Colonna under the Emperor's, and Sforza has a French knife at his throat. The only man in Rome I trust to think about the hired swords of Italy as men, not only swords, is you."

You slid further down into the water, blowing tiny bubbles at the surface and letting them tickle your face. Despite your silence, his frown down at you seemed to know what you were thinking inside: *Sorry all you have is me.*

“When people list the virtues,” he continued, “justice, honor, charity, you know the one they most often leave out? Existing. If you don’t have that you don’t have any of them.”

You nodded, remembering your theology tutor making you read Saint Anselm’s argument that a thing that exists is superior to a thing that doesn’t, and that God—the best of all things—exists more absolutely than anything, always and everywhere, or at least that’s what you took from it.

“So don’t compare yourself to the imaginary perfect version of you who doesn’t exist.” He tossed his shirt onto the bench, and started to unwind the bandages which cocooned his scar-striped chest—so many scars, so young. “The best sword that could ever be made in all the world is no good to me compared to the sword that’s actually in my hand. Your father didn’t give you the most important asset of the family—the cardinalship—out of pity or necessity, he did it because he judged you were the best the family could have in Rome, as I am in Urbino.”

“That’s easy for Your Grace to say. You’re perfect.”

“My father certainly thought so.” Mischievous is the only word to describe the sudden sparkle in His Grace’s eyes, the cat-like smile of springing a trap. “You know my mother died when I was born—so many daughters then one last chance for an heir. I don’t think you’ve met my much older half-brother, Antonio? He’s one of my captains now. He wanted to be father’s heir, challenged me for it when I was ten and he was twenty-seven, but our father said he didn’t have what it takes to lead like I do. And he was right.” Duke Guidobaldo tossed away the bandages and let you see in full profile for a moment what was there, and what was not. As he plunged into the water all his body language, those confident shoulders, were a man’s, your mind never even groped toward the word *woman*, but you had seen clearly what those bandages hid, strapped tight across his chest, and what was *not* between his legs. “Don’t doubt your father’s choice, Cardinal Sanseverino. He was a great leader, and great chooser of men. As mine was.”

Once you recovered your breath, you stammered out your question. “Wh-o ee—”

“Who else knows?” he translated. “Our duchess knows, our sisters, a few doctors and servants, and yourself.” He held your gaze. “We said we want you as the Roman partner of our labors, and that we want the man who has our back to know us well. Now, I want *Your Eminence* to go to Rome,” it was the first time anyone had used the title with you, “and trust yourself as much as I am trusting you.”

SELLING SWORDS IN SAINT PETER’S CITY

So here you are, new to Rome, new to the Vatican, to the College of Cardinals, new to having the fates of thousands—all the hired swords of Italy and all their families, Montefeltro, Sanseverino, Malatesta—all resting on you. And new to trusting in your father and yourself that you really can do it.

In a weird way it’s simple. You have armies to sell. The other cardinals, and the monarchs they represent, will want to buy. Win-win. And you want to establish yourself in Rome, make friends, learn how things work, and lay the groundwork for a long career.

Such simple goals mean you have a lot of flexibility. It doesn’t matter very much to you who becomes pope—a kinsman would be nice but you aren’t in Rome to ensure a particular outcome, there will be a market for armies no matter what. Advancing allied families would be

good, but you have *so many* allied families that it's hard to imagine any papal candidate succeeding without backing from at least one if not several of the Colonna, della Rovere, Carafa, and Sforza families. A French invasion of Milan would likely hurt your Sforza kinsmen, but it would also make great opportunities for mercenaries, and your della Rovere kinsmen are allies of King Charles, so it could be good for your connections either way. You can be flexible, see what different factions offer you in return for your support, and it's hard to imagine any outcome of the election that would be unilaterally bad for you.

Where it gets complicated is that mercenaries, as you know, are people. While those who want to hire them will mostly just be thinking of the numbers (needing X-many armies), you know that a mercenary's commission can be life-changing: establishing contacts and friendships that last through future campaigns, learning the terrain around a city or region making one an expert and likely to earn higher pay if hired there again. Battles can establish friendships, paving the way for more serious commissions, marriage alliances, or noble titles. His Grace Uncle Fabrizio Colonna is Grand Constable of Naples and a Duke because he earned those titles from King Ferrante in return for mercenary operations in the past. All the titles your father earned, and lost, and earned again, including the estate where you grew up, were rewards for mercenary commissions. Your parents married because your father served with your mother's father, and more than once loved ones and relatives have been *spared* after *losing* battles because the enemy commanders who captured them had been their allies in earlier years. Commissions establish connections, trust, the web which, to a man who risks his life in other people's wars, makes that worthwhile. And, of course, each mercenary also has a home, or a couple of them, so it means one thing to the Duke of Sora to help Venice to fight Milan, and a very different thing if Sora itself is in the armies' path.

So, while everyone who comes to you to hire mercenaries will be thinking mainly of racking up numbers, it will be *your* job to know that *each mercenary is a living human being*, and to find commissions that will be good for them, in ways beyond the cash.

The cash does matter. Fundamentally it costs 20,000 a year to feed and equip an army, so 20,000 is the **minimum** a mercenary commander can accept without his men just going home. 20,000 will *feed* but cannot *pay* the men, leaving the commander to dip into his own funds to pay them, or to promise they can loot whatever they capture (at such low pay it's basically impossible to keep the men from looting *even if* the commander orders it).

At 30,000 the commander can give decent pay to his soldiers, but have nothing left over for himself, requiring that he dip into his own funds, or loot, if he wants to have something to support his family, castle etc.

Thus, 40,000 is the **minimum pay at which the mercenary commander is actually earning enough out of the bargain to sustain his home and family**. 50,000 is thus *good* pay, 60,000+ very good pay.

And there are younger mercenaries in your extended family too, **fledgling mercenaries**, men barely older than you who have trained under fathers and uncles and are ready to lead armies but don't yet have armies of their own, and are seeking a patron who will lay down the 40,000 it takes to raise a new army from nothing, and launch them on their new careers. They *can't* take less than 40,000, they need to buy horses and spears and things, though sometimes if they are offered 30,000 the family itself might scrounge up the last 10,000 to let a son launch on a good career.

But there is so much more to a mercenary's choice than one year's cash. Marriages can mean a lot, especially when they bring powerful connections and likely future commissions, and

many mercenaries will happily take 20,000 plus a bride from a powerful family over an offer of 60,000. Titles mean a lot too, especially since one must rise in rank to rise in military rank. No one will serve under a man who has a higher title than himself, and the highest commanders are expected to be a duke, or at a minimum a marquis. Your father was Marquis of Castelnuovo Scrivia *briefly*, and even though he lost the *land*, you never lose a *title*, so the fact that he was a marquis meant that counts and lords like the Malatesta or Colonna could and would serve under him (while he himself served *under* your Uncle Giovanni Duke of Sora even though Uncle Giovanni was a much younger and less skilled general).

For a mid-career mercenary, a ducal title even somewhere far away like England or Portugal can open up many opportunities, and for a start-of-career mercenary like your siblings or the younger sons of counts and lords, even a count title can let them transition from being a courtier and lieutenant to commanding their own forces. That is worth taking 20,000 or 30,000 for the season, even if it means dipping into one's own pockets to pay the men. And there are other honors: wearables like robes or jewelry which let one impress people at court, exotic animals which advertise one's connections to faraway places, all can enhance a mercenary's reputation, especially if he is one of many mercenaries at a royal court.

And there is honor.

Every mercenary, you've learned, has his own sense of honor, Duke Guidobaldo with his speech about Mars and Minerva so different from Uncle Giovanni Duke of Sora who takes pride in fighting his own wars instead of other men's, both different from Uncle Fabrizio Colonna who likes to make all his battles be about the Ghibelline faction and imperial dignity, even when he's fighting about something totally irrelevant like the crown of Naples. Every mercenary has different needs and preferences, different career stages, and different honor. Basically all your extended family are Ghibellines, but even that means different things, since Fabrizio Colonna will never fight for a Guelph cause even if you offered him every ounce of gold in Italy, while Duke Guidobaldo is loud about Ghibelline pride and eager to fight Guelph cities, but was willing enough to fight for Guelph Florence when they offered 10,000 extra pay. Even the wild Malatesta have honor of their strange kind, not toward enemies (burn! sack! kill!) but they prefer to be their own commanders, and would rather let their men and city starve than serve under someone they don't respect.

And, of course, there is the problem of kinsmen fighting kinsmen. While most mercenaries are willing to face a cousin or son-in-law in battle *if necessary*, they strongly prefer to avoid it. This can be very tricky, since, as you know better than anyone, almost all Italy's mercenaries are kinsmen, and it will never happen that one side has *all* the money and can afford *all* the mercenaries—both sides in any coming war will be hiring. Sometimes one side will hire mostly Swiss, in which case the other side can hire mostly Italians, but it rarely works out so simply, so once one mercenary accepts a commission to fight for or against one city, it is essential that all close kinsmen be informed since they won't want to take commissions from the other side.

Thus, your job, as people in Rome ask you for armies, is to think hard about which commission to match to which mercenary, what combinations will create the connections that will benefit each of your family members most, avoid close kinsmen fighting one another, and to think about what to ask for beyond cash, since a cardinal shopping for armies likely won't know which of your cousins is a count already but needs a wife, and which desperately needs a count title so he can lead more men.

There is also a question of *speed* with mercenary contracts. Often there will be only a

trickle of offers at the beginning, then high bidding as the war season draws close, then a few more small bids at the end when all the martial powers run low on cash. A mercenary will usually make the most money if he accepts a contract in that middle glut, *but* accepting a contract *earlier than most* has its advantages, since the first mercenary to pick a side can pick any side, while later ones will usually have their choices shaped by who is already on one side or another. In many ways, the first mercenary contract of the season is the most important, determining the likely fall of all the others (i.e. Montefeltro on *this* side therefore likely the Bentivoglios on the other since they're least related). While you do want to pursue commissions for as many of your mercenary relatives as possible, you want to think carefully about which you contract first, and they themselves will consider it a sign of extra friendship if you choose to finalize their commissions before others.

In addition to all the mercenaries you *are* related to (Sanseverino, Montefeltro, Colonna, Sforza, and della Rovere), your family has given you strong connections to two mercenary families who *aren't* kinsmen.

The Bentivoglio family, noble but untitled, rule as unofficial tyrants over the Republic of Bologna (though very overtly). They have long been mercenaries, and members of their family have served alongside your kinsmen many times. They are Guelphs, so your family has often fought against them, but respectfully, and while they would be as content to see your brothers across a battle line as beside them, they trust you reasonably. Your father respected the Bentivoglios and holds no particular grudge. Even the Bentivoglios will listen to your advice about what sides to fight for in the coming war (they don't have any representative at the conclave after all, though they are Sforza kinsmen), and since they aren't kin, and are Guelphs, they're good ones to sell to sides to fight *against* those your close family might be on, since it will let you weaken Guelphs, and will mean that the enemy commanders would treat your kinsmen with respect if they're captured.

Similarly, the Alidosi family also comes from Bologna, and though less powerful have some mercenaries in the family. Their connection to you is through Duke Guidobaldo, since Federico da Montefeltro was raised by an Alidosi stepmother, making the current generation of Alidosi your maternal grandfather's foster cousins. It's tenuous, but a woman who lived with and raised Federico da Montefeltro for almost twenty years is actually a stronger *personal* source of affection than the bond between two cousins who have never met, so the family takes it seriously.

Technical steps of finalizing a mercenary contract:

1. Receive an offer from a potential buyer (usually a player, very rarely an NPC), either in person at the session, or through a letter.
2. Look at your quick reference list of the needs and preferences of different mercenaries (provided later in this document).
3. Suggest a specific mercenary which might be a fit for that buyer, and negotiate with the player (or NPC) the details of the offer.
4. When a sale is final, **report all details of the sale (what army, who was the buyer, what was the final price/terms) to the orchestrators.** (You can send the professor an email.)

Finally, when your brothers sent you off to Rome, they reminded you over and over (the elder ones in letters, the younger in person) of one thing in Rome that sounds irrelevant but can

have a big impact on the season's wars: the canonization of new saints. The pope will confirm several new saints, and a new saint can make a *major, major impact* on military recruitment. Basically a lot of foot soldiers (and many higher-rank soldiers too) are *very* religious (and superstitious), and really care about having saints on their side in battle. Every time a new saint gets approved, that new saint gets a big burst of enthusiasm, which means lots of extra soldiers flocking to any armies fighting for someone that saint favors (the city they're from, the family they're from, the region they're from, etc.) There are forty finalists for canonization, and most of them are connected to some place or family that is likely to get involved in the war: some would favor Emperor Maximilian, some Spain or Portugal, some one Italian city or another, and every one of these could have a big impact on how successful different sides are at recruitment, making armies stronger or weaker, and making men demand more or less pay. You want to pay close attention to the progress of canonization, and make sure, if you can, to keep the commanders you really care about (your brothers at least) from having to fight *against* sides that just got a new saint, since those battles are likely to be extra difficult for their commanders. As you figure out what side you and your kin will be supporting, you might want to talk to **Cardinal Achilles Sangiorgio**, the one in charge of approving new saints, to encourage the approval of ones that would favor your sides, and discourage the canonization of those that would favor the opposite. It is one major way you can contribute to war successes (and avoid war failures) better from Rome than from the field.

BEYOND THE SALE OF SWORDS

As for your other goals, you have a lot of marriages to arrange. Rome is about to host the largest meeting of powerful families in the world, and the vast majority of the next generation's important marriages will be contracted. You have a huge number of brothers and sisters to marry. Some of them are already married, but many of the younger ones are not, and your two oldest brothers are also marriageable, since the eldest Gianfrancesco (who inherited your father's title of Count) was just widowed, and the second Gaspare "Fracasso" has been holding out hoping his patron Emperor Maximilian may give him a noble title so he can get a better bride. Also, many mercenary families you are tied to who don't have their own cardinals have asked you to represent them, and the more peripheral or weak the branch the more likely they are to need your help. The sons and daughters of the Carafa, Colonna, della Rovere, and Sforza families will rely on the Carafa, Colonna, della Rovere, and Sforza cardinals to arrange their marriages, but you are the best opportunity for your own Sanseverino relatives, for the Malatestas (though a woman must be brave to cope with such wild husbands), and for others related to the house of Montefeltro, especially the children of Aunt Gentile's second marriage to the powerful Genoese (Campo)Fregoso family, and Duke Guidobaldo's brother-in-law and battle partner Francesco Gonzaga Marquess of Mantua (one of the most desirable grooms in Italy). And while you have *not* been tasked directly by Duke Guidobaldo to find a marriage for his likely-to-be-adopted-heir young Francesco Maria della Rovere (son of the Duke of Sora), you know both Duke Guidobaldo and the boy's father Uncle Giovanni della Rovere will take your advice on the matter very seriously, though they will also be heeding the advice of your other della Rovere uncle Julius, and of Guidobaldo's godfather Cardinal Piccolomini.

You also have some more specific goals regarding specific relatives:

His Grace Uncle Giovanni della Rovere comes from the mighty and ambitious faction of

Sixtus, which pushed hard to secure the papacy last time, and likely will again. You have not yet met Uncle Julius directly, but the name of Giuliano della Rovere is so (in)famous, that all across Europe if one says just “della Rovere” everyone knows one must mean him. You know that Uncle Julius has been in France for the past year working closely with King Charles (and likely with your banished uncle Antonello Sanseverino Prince of Salerno) and is likely at the center of whatever the French are planning for the coming days. You will want to plan to meet with Uncle Julius as soon as possible (i.e. in the “Zero Period”) to get to know him, learn what his plans are, and decide whether to become a part of his faction.

In another year, the decision to support your della Rovere uncles might be an easy yes, but since rumor has it that King Charles intends to attack the Sforza of Milan (who are allies and kinsmen), and King Charles has been fighting with Emperor Maximilian (whom the Colonna support), it may be that you’ll have to choose between your della Rovere kinsmen and the Sforza and or Colonna. The Sforza are very important to your family—you have Sforza blood in your veins through several grandparents, and they launched your father’s career and have hired most of your brothers too. Your family still owns lands around Milan as well, and collects rents from them, so your family could be doubly impoverished if Milan falls, both through the wealthy Sforza no longer being there to hire you, and through losing a big chunk of your income from land. You might have much to gain if you support Charles and he conquers a big chunk of Italy (he’ll need to put sub-rulers in places he conquers, possibly your brothers!), but he also intends to conquer *all the Sanseverino lands* since they’re in Milan and Naples, so if he does will he really let you keep them? And if he tries and fails, do you really want to end up an enemy of the Sforza and Ferrante, who would likely banish you and your family as he banished your uncle Antonello? And you have brothers on all sides of the conflict. Your eldest brother **Count Gianfrancesco Sanseverino** (who inherited your father’s title) is a courtier and trusted friend of King Charles. On the other hand, your second brother **Gaspere “Fracasso” Sanseverino** is Emperor Maximilian’s trusted councilor and favorite jousting champion (a position of *major trust and influence* when the Emperor *invites you to aim a lance at him!*). And there’s also (grr) **Galahad “Fortunato” Sanseverino**, the traitor brother who fought for Ludovico Sforza against your father when he was fighting for Bona of Savoy (and got super rich and powerful from doing so).

[In fact in Italian your third brother’s name would be Galeazzo but he often used the French form Galahad, and we are using that or he’s too easy to mix up with Galeazzo Sforza. I also apologize on behalf of history for the fact that all 3 of your important brothers have names starting with G, and two have nicknames starting with F. It’s real history and the names are cruel sometimes. If it helps, remember the jousting is “Fracasso” like fracking which involves hitting stuff hard so it splits open, while Fortunato i.e. Fortunate is the one who’s super sexy, rich, and powerful.]

Galahad Fortunato Sanseverino makes things extra complicated. You have no love for (and basically no memories of) this estranged brother, but he’s still good friends with the family’s scion Count Gianfrancesco (your oldest brother), and, more important, Galahad is undeniably the richest and most powerful member of your family—nicknamed *Fortunato* because people say he must be Fortune’s favorite son, rising so high (and because they say he’s the handsomest man in Italy). Galahad Fortunato advanced from fighting for Ludovico Sforza, to commanding all Ludovico’s armies, to becoming what he is now: Duke Ludovico’s primary lover and constant companion. (Yes, to be 100% clear, your sexy and charismatic 3rd-eldest brother is Duke

Ludovico's boyfriend, publicly acknowledged as such in front of everyone—nobility can get away with almost anything.) Galahad is the duke's most trusted adviser, and has so much authority in Milan he's allowed to give commands in the duke's place like a second duke. He's treated like a member of the ducal family, engaged to marry Duke Ludovico's illegitimate daughter, already sometimes signs his letters "Galahad Sforza Sanseverino," and is welcome even in the Duke and Duchess's private quarters, where few dare tread. Duchess Beatrice d'Este, very powerful in her own right, *also* apparently really likes and trusts Galahad, going on hunting trips with him and playing croquet with him daily, he's just that charming, and the Duchess isn't jealous of his relationship with her husband, you hear that she's happy the duke has a male lover since it meant kicking out the duke's previous *female* favorite lover Cecelia Gallerani, whom the duchess hated. In sum, Galahad's relationship with Duke Ludovico has made him the fourth most powerful man in Northern Italy after the Doge of Venice, Duke Ludovico, and Francesco Gonzaga (to make things *more* complicated, you hear Francesco Gonzaga and Galahad are feuding, argh). Needless to say, if Ludovico loses Milan then his lover will fall with him, and while you feel torn about this estranged brother who fought against your father, he's been good to the family, and the steady stream of cash he sends from Milan was the only thing which kept the family from poverty the last few years. If the family loses Galahad's wealth and influence, what will happen if times get tough? And yet the King of France would make such a powerful patron, and a terrifying enemy. Brothers on three sides... such a tangle...

Also entangled with Milan is the region of Savoy, the duchy between France and Italy. Savoy is technically part of the Empire, and its duke is one of the seven Prince Electors of the Empire, very important princes who select the next Emperor (and can demand a handsome bribe for it). The current Duke of Savoy, **Carlo Amadeo**, is only three years old, so real power is in the hands of his mother **Blanche of Montferrat**, whose mother was a Sforza (Duke Ludovico's youngest sister), and whose father came from a branch of the Paleologos ruling family of the Byzantine empire. Savoy is important to the Empire, but is also very vulnerable to France—nearly helpless in fact—and for years France has been cultivating power over it through marriages, so that King Charles's mother was the aunt of the current young duke, while another aunt of the current duke is Lady Bona of Savoy, mother of the imprisoned Gian Galeazzo Sforza. Savoy is going to be a big issue because France can't get its armies to Milan without going through Savoy, so Charles is going to work hard to negotiate safe passage, which the Sforza and Maximilian won't want. Tricky. One of Uncle Giovanni Duke of Sora's cousins, **Domenico della Rovere di Vinovo** comes from Savoy, and will know a lot about what's going on there—valuable information.

While considering Charles vs. Maximilian and Milan, you mustn't forget Spain, since Queen Isabella and King Ferdinand control Naples through King Ferrante, including your family's lands where you grew up. They too may have a favorite candidate for the papacy, or may end up siding with Charles, or with Maximilian, and keeping them as friends (rather than enemies) would be helpful since so many of your brothers and sisters are still in Naples, and most of your current family lands. Uncle Carafa—your closest tie to Spain—is a vassal of King Ferrante (as you technically are as well in return for your father's Count title) so if Their Majesties of Spain do have plans for this election they'll likely be expecting Uncle Carafa to advance them, and you too. Uncle Carafa is a very weary man in a very difficult position as the right-hand man of a mad king. You don't know what he'll be trying to accomplish at the conclave (King Ferrante may well have packed him off to Rome with insane orders separate from any sane ones he gets from Ferdinand and Isabella), but you'd like to do what you can to

help Uncle Carafa, both to keep your family on the good side of King Ferrante, and to help a man who has been kind to you, and has a rough life. You may or may not want to help him actually accomplish his boss's orders (he may not *want* to carry out the orders) but you definitely want to help him personally in whatever way you can, especially in ways that will keep the Sanseverino in the good graces of the Aragonese monarchs.

With ties to France, Spain, and the Empire, and uncles and brothers connected to all three as well, it may be tempting to pick a faction based on which one seems most likely to win the papacy. But since all your family's goals are long-term, not short-term, **the question of which faction is likely to have a pope actually doesn't matter to you as much as whether the people in that faction are people you want to work with:** reliable, sincere about helping you, generous in their remuneration for your support, people who will respect mercenary honor and seem like good partners for the Houses of Sanseverino (and Montefeltro) long-term. And a faction which *doesn't* get a pope will very likely have much need of mercenaries, both short-term and long-term, and be extra grateful to an ally who stands by them. Mercenaries know well that some of the best friendships are forged in the grimmest moments, which is why when a mercenary family loses everything (kicked out of their home city by a conqueror, for example), fellow mercenaries usually welcome them as guests, and give them money and support to get them back onto their feet again, knowing that those who receive help in their worst hours will repay that help with sincere gratitude. Powerful men have many friends, but a friend in rough times is a friend indeed. Thus, while you do want to think about which faction wins, if you need to choose between kinsmen you really can choose the ones you like and want to work with most long-term, rather worrying too much about the likely immediate outcome of *this* papal election. Even if the side you chose loses everything, if you're their lifeline in their hardest hour, that will form the kind of friendship that lasts generations, like Duke Guidobaldo has with Piccolomini, or your father with the Sforza.

Thus, in order to decide between your kinsmen, **you'll want to try to meet as soon as you can (i.e. in the "Zero Period" if possible) with all four of your close relatives in the conclave: Uncle Julius della Rovere, Uncle Oliviero Carafa, Great Uncle Giovanni Colonna, and your cousin Cardinal Ascanio Sforza.** After talking with each, getting to see how they treat you now that you're a cardinal, not just a boy, then you can make the decision for yourself about who to stick closest with among your relatives at the conclave.

When you talk with Cardinal Colonna, you'll also want to ask him, as the Ghibelline leader, what you can do as a good Ghibelline to advance the interests of the faction. Your father wasn't like the Colonna such a gung-ho Ghibelline that he'd put party before practicality, and you're not inclined to either, but the party's strength is an asset. Ghibellines in a pinch will often get help from other Ghibellines, and you sleep better at night knowing your many brothers out there in the field have many comrades of many families far beyond yours who would help them *for the party*, in a pinch, not just for pay. Thus, while you don't want to hurl yourself headstrong into anything that would ignite the feud, if there are things you can do to reaffirm your allegiance to the Ghibelline party, especially to confirm it to Cardinal Colonna, that will be beneficial for your family in general, by securing further friendship from the largest political alliance in Italy.

Thinking all this through helps you realize anew how much you have in common with your youngest and closest uncle, Duke Guidobaldo da Montefeltro of Urbino, the man who says he wants to call you the "partner at his back." Like you, His Grace is between these factions. He doesn't have your ties to Naples or to Spain, but his mother was a Sforza and his likely adopted heir is a della Rovere, it doesn't get much more caught between than that. And, like your father,

he is willing to take any side when paid to be a Mars, but you do believe he would stand by you like Minerva if you stand by him. And that, unlike the others who all have their sides already, if you write to him to say you think X faction is the best, he'd move with you. You know he'd be proud to help defend his mother's Sforza kinsmen in Milan, but he would also be willing to take French gold, not if the pay was *higher*, but if the guarantees of safety for those he cares about (Urbino, Mantua, his godfather Piccolomini, his sisters, *you*) were better. To be his partner of politics long-term is... feels like the most equal partnership you're likely to find, that (unlike your older uncles) he would listen to your plans instead of just expecting you to help with his. So you want to do well by the Duke of Urbino, to help him make stronger ties to whatever side you pick, to choose well where to help him sell his blade, and generally to stand by him like... like someone worthy of the loyalty of a Minerva.

One small complication that comes with being a partner to Duke Guidobaldo is the issue of his godfather **Cardinal Piccolomini**. The man himself is nice as much as you know, a scholar and peaceful sort, and he has some marriage ties with the della Rovere, but the Piccolomini family are long-time rivals of your stepmother's family the Malavolti. So far as you understand, the feud started about 150 years ago when the two families squabbled over the position of Bishop of Siena, and the Malavolti were part of a conspiracy to try to overthrow the republic and create an aristocratic oligarchy, which the Piccolomini were core to thwarting. While the Malavolti may actually have been the first aggressors, the Piccolomini have harmed them many times in the intervening centuries in all the traditional methods of a feud: political pressure, banishments, cruel taxation, exclusion from political power, property damage, arresting and persecuting their clients, and direct street violence and murder. Your mother *hates* the Piccolomini, not the cardinal but the family in general, and really wants to see them weakened, so the other families of Siena will be less under their thumb. But you know that Duke Guidobaldo is ferociously protective of and loyal to Cardinal Piccolomini—as a personal, not a family matter—and the only thing His Grace specifically asked you to do at the conclave, other than find a good buyer for his sword and a good wife for Gonzaga, is to **do all you can to help and be friends with Cardinal Piccolomini**. Making your mother happy while also respecting Duke Guidobaldo's bond with Piccolomini may be tricky. You could do nothing, just sitting out of an old feud, but it's important to keep it in mind.

There are also the Malatestas—not in Rome, obviously. Since the deaths of the two who were married to your aunts, they have basically no friends or allies anymore at all, except for you and some vague family ties to the d'Este, and to the Pico family of Mirandola (the family of the infamous excommunicated heretic). They used to think of the Montefeltros as allies, but since Duke Guidobaldo's father died battling *against* the Malatesta, his feelings toward them aren't exactly warm, though you've no reason to think they're vengeful either. The Malatestas do not want much to do with the religious side of the Church, but they do want to be reconnected to power, so any connections you can forge between them and anyone, whether via marriages, contracts, or other ways, will earn the deep gratitude of... well, of a bunch of rampaging quasi-pagan plunderers, but you'd much rather be on their good side than their bad side, and Uncle Giovanni says that men with bad reputations can often make wonderful allies since you can get them to do the dishonorable work, the part that would make you hated (like when a city really does need to be sacked) and still share the profits while taking on only more respectable jobs yourself and keeping an unsullied reputation. Having a Malatesta force in one's alliance is very useful (the threat "Surrender or we'll let the Malatesta lead the charge!" opens a lot of gates), so earning their gratitude would be handy, but it's not something you're willing to go out

on a limb for, or put above advancing any of the families closer to you, or that you respect more.

And finally—though in some ways this may be the most important task of all—you want to make friends in the College of Cardinals. You’re young. You’re new. You’re going to be a colleague of these people for the rest of your life. It’s as important for you to get to know them and develop some rapport as it is for a mercenary like Duke Guidobaldo to get to know Italy’s other mercenary generals. Especially the younger ones. Duke Guidobaldo made a point of singling you out, getting to know you, because you’re close in age and he realized you’ll be political partners for a very long time. The same is true of the other younger cardinals in Rome—they’re men you’re going to be working with, competing with, negotiating with, helping, or opposing for many, many years. Perhaps one of them will come to be your partner in the Conclave as Duke Guidobaldo has his brother-in-law Federico Gonzaga as his partner of the battlefield. Perhaps one of them could be a friend. Perhaps one of them has a sister who might wed one of your brothers, making a real partnership, the kind that shapes a generation. You don’t know what you’ll find—perhaps they’ll all be stuffy from going to priest school and spurn someone with mercenary education—but you would like to find allies (or even friends) among the younger cardinals, and look forward to meeting them, in hope.

The most natural young cardinal to befriend is, of course, your della Rovere-branch cousin **Cardinal Raffaele Riario**. The others close to you in age are fascinatingly varied. Two are as noble as could be, the kind of men your brothers aspire to work for: **Cardinal Michel de Bucy**, the illegitimate brother of the King of France, and **Cardinal Ippolito d’Este**, brother of the Duke of Ferrara, the noblest house in Italy. Both are a couple years older than you, and both from such powerful families that managing to secure the friendship of either could make your family’s fortunes for a generation. Your wise stepmother also told you to make sure not to ignore the **papal chaplain Alessandro Farnese**, since he too comes from an important family and is likely to rise to be a cardinal in time, as well as the Vice-Chancellor’s son **Archbishop (Cesare) Valentino Borgia**, who will likely also be promoted by his hard-working Spanish father and may be a core Vatican administrator for many years as you live in Rome.

The other Benedictines at the conclave are *technically* allies since you’re also a Benedictine, but that’s laughable since you’re basically all sham Benedictines just in it for the money, and couldn’t care less about the order, beside which the Benedictines aren’t one central organization like the Franciscans and Dominicans, they’re mostly a catch-all term for a huge array of old-fashioned monasteries with very little to do with each other. So you *might* get a friendly welcome from **the Patriarch of Venice** and the young Vatican clerk **Brother Tillio**, but even **Ippolito d’Este** and your uncle-in-law **Paolo Campofregoso** are technically Benedictines, and that’s a worse joke than you being one.

And then there is the oddest detail of your family tree: there are many branches of Sanseverinos in Italy, some allied with the Orsini family instead of the Ghibelline faction. One of them is your cousin (third cousin once removed was it?) Caterina Sanseverino, who married an Orsini, and their daughter Alfonsina Sanseverino Orsini then made a very strange marriage indeed: Piero de Medici, eldest son and heir of Lorenzo de Medici, the strange merchant who pulls the strings of Florence. This means the only other cardinal younger than you are—Lorenzo’s second son **Cardinal Giovanni “Leo” de Medici**—is technically your cousin-in-law. Thinking of him as a *cousin* feels... odd. The boy does have noble Orsini blood in his veins (his mother, Lorenzo’s wife, was Clarice Orsini), but fundamentally the Medici are like all Florentines, common men, the kind your family hires as servants or rank-and-file soldiers, or like the courtier-prisoners your father used to bring back from his wars, the kind of

men you own, command, or trade, not peers. There's not a single knighthood in the family, not one of them fit to lead even a small brigade. It's strange, really, that the Orsini made such a marriage—certainly neither your father nor your mother nor your stepmother would *ever* allow any of *your* siblings to make such a match, mixing noble Sanseverino blood with merchant nobodies who've never held a lance. That kind of marriage is usually the sign of a great family weakening—possibly sign of the Guelph faction weakening in general? But regardless, the marriage happened, and there he is, the young Medici cardinal, and rich as heck, and you hear impressive things about his father, though mostly about his father's peacemaking efforts which, well, are rather the *opposite* of what your family does.

Your instinct is *not* to address him as “cousin” when you meet him, and no one would think it odd if you don't since the family connection is very distant, but his is an influential family, and maybe the Orsini blood has come through to make them more noble? Of course, if this year's war season takes the shape you suspect Uncle Guidobaldo and your other Ghibelline kinsmen would wish, Florence itself may well be the top target of the wars, in which case getting to know more about the Medici cardinal and his resources could help prepare for that, and it will presumably be him who pays the fat ransom for the release of his father and siblings if your kinsmen capture them in war. You're curious to meet him, but your best guess is that he'll be a fish out of water among the grand princes in the College of Cardinals, like a page boy in a comic play suddenly asked to dress up in his master's clothes, and if that's true then “cousin” certainly won't feel right. But he will be there in Rome with you for many years, so you need to establish *some* relationship. Maybe he can be a little like a squire? Fortunately, there are far better young Cardinals to befriend in Rome, so while you'll keep the young merchant in mind (he's rich?) it's much more important that you to get to know the young cardinals from great houses, especially noble Ippolito d'Este, royal-blooded Michel de Bucy, and your cousin and likely lifelong partner in Roman matters Raffaele Riario—a good friendship with any one of them might matter more than anything.

FAMILY QUICK REFERENCE LIST: Player name tags have red dots for uncles, blue for cousins

ALIDOSI & BENTIVOGLIO = Bolognese mercenary families, friends but not kinsmen.

(CAMPO)FREGOSO = Major Genoese nobles, 2nd husband of twice-widowed Aunt Gentile

CARAFÀ = Most powerful family in Naples under the royal family, uncle Carafa is a cardinal.

COLONNA = Ghibelline faction leaders, from Rome, held in high regard by all your kin.

DELLA ROVERE AND RIARIO = Genoese family of Pope Sixtus IV, *very* ambitious & powerful.

GONZAGA = Ruling family of Mantua, close marriage allies of Guidobaldo da Montefeltro

MALATESTA = Wild mercenaries from Rimini, virtually sun-worshippers, kinsmen but unreliable.

MALAVOLTI = Stepmother's family, minor nobles from Siena, rivals/enemies of the Piccolomini.

MONTEFELTRO = Your mother's family from Urbino, hub of the giant web of marriages.

PICCOLOMINI = Most powerful family of Siena, owed a debt of honor by the Montefeltros.

ORSINI = *Guelph* faction leaders from Rome, party foes, kinsmen of your relatives in Salerno.

SANSEVERINO = Your main family, Milanese but with landed titles in the Kingdom of Naples.

SFORZA = Formerly-mercenary conquerors of Milan, your kin through several grandparents.

- Father: **Roberto Sanseverino d'Aragona Marquis of Castelnuovo Scrivia** died 5 years ago
- Stepmom: **Lucrezia Malavolti** from Siena, alive. (Mother: **Bettina da Montefeltro**, dead).
- Eldest brother: **Count Gianfrancesco Sanseverino**, envoy from Milan to France, widower.
- 2nd eldest brother: **Gaspere da Corregio Sanseverino** aka "**Fracasso**," famous jousting and courtier of Emperor Maximilian, with the Emperor in Germany, unmarried.
- 3rd eldest brother: **Galahad "Fortunato" Sanseverino**, lover of Duke Ludovico Sforza of Milan, fought against your father, estranged but richest & most powerful family member.
- **Uncle Giovanni della Rovere** Count of Sora (age 35) nephew of Pope Sixtus, married to **Aunt Giovanna di Montefeltro**. Their two-year-old second son, your cousin **Francesco Maria della Rovere**, is likely to be Duke Guidobaldo's adopted heir.
 - o His brother **Cardinal Giovanni della Rovere "Uncle Julius" (player)** faction leader
 - o Cousin **Domenico di Vinovo della Rovere (NPC)**.
 - o Their nephew **Cardinal Raffaele Riario (player)** is heir to the faction.
- **Aunt Costanza da Montefeltro Sanseverino** (age 26) Regent of Salerno (near home) for her banished husband **Antonello Sanseverino** Prince of Salerno. Has young son **Robertino**.
- **Cardinal Orsini, cousin (player)** (57) Guelph leader, cousin through the Salerno branch.
- **Uncle Oliviero Carafa, Cardinal of Naples (player)** (age 62) Dominican leader, uncle through your sister Giulia who married his nephew. Serves Mad King Ferrante of Naples.
- **Uncle Fabrizio Colonna, Grand Constable of Naples** (age 32) duke, married to **Aunt Agnese da Montefeltro** (age 22) who's in Rome. His uncle is **Cardinal Colonna (player)**.
- **The Merry Malatesta Widows: Aunt Gentile** (age 44) married Carlo Malatesta, was widowed, then married Agostino Fragoso of Genoa, had eight kids, widowed again; & **Aunt Elisabetta** (age 28) widow of Roberto Malatesta Lord of Rimini, now a nun (Franciscan).
- **Paolo Campofregoso, Cardinal (player)** (62) estranged cousin-in-law, exiled ex-Doge
- **Uncle Guidobaldo da Montefeltro Duke of Urbino** (age 20), and his duchess **Elisabetta Gonzaga** (age 21) sister of the duke's war partner **Francesco Gonzaga of Mantua** (26).
 - o **Antonio da Montefeltro** (age 47) Guidobaldo's illegitimate half-brother & servant
- **Cardinal Piccolomini of Siena (player)** (63) Guidobaldo's godfather, stepmom's enemy.
- **Cardinal Giovanni "Leo" de Medici (player)** (16) merchant scum, cousin-in-law via Orsini

MERCENARIES & THEIR NEEDS (IN MORE DETAIL THAN THE PUBLIC LIST)

Giovanni Bentivoglio, First Citizen of Bologna (Guelph): First Citizen or “Tyrant” of Bologna. Has had a long and successful career as a mercenary captain, during which he was saved by Lorenzo “the Magnificent” from a life of imprisonment, so he owes the Medici and will likely help them in a pinch. Bologna has been plagued by rebellions so he is seeking to be recognized as a duke. Married to an (illegitimate) Sforza princess, marriage ties to Mirandola & to the Malatesta family of Rimini. Bentivoglio wants a ducal title more than anything and will almost certainly be easily recruited by Emperor Maximilian or the potential pope, since they’re the ones who can make him a duke. He’s reliable and experienced, and won’t do anything unpredictable, and will probably be willing to fight for way under standard pay if he gets his ducal title out of it. He has some unmarried kids and will probably be asking his Sforza kinsmen to find matches for them. Weakening Bologna would weaken the Guelphs and Florence. Cardinal Savelli has power there.

WON’T ATTACK: Bologna; may not attack Florence, Rimini, Mirandola, Milan, but maybe for big pay

SPECIALIZES FIGHTING IN: Ferrara and the Kingdom of Naples.

Ermes Bentivoglio (Guelph): Young and promising captain, son of Giovanni Bentivoglio First Citizen of Bologna. Has practiced and studied hard under his father and his father’s mercenary allies. Currently unmarried, and really wants to be knighted, which should be easy since lots of people can grant knighthoods. Likely to work for cheap if someone makes him a count, very likely to fight for whoever hires his father.

WON’T ATTACK: Bologna and its allies.

SPECIALIZES FIGHTING IN: Central Italy especially Bologna, Mirandola, Rimini, Urbino.

Tiberto Brandolini (Guelph): From the village of Bagnacavallo near Ravenna, a port on the eastern coast of Italy south of Rimini, with ties to Byzantium and the East. Trained in a mixture of Italian, Greek, and Turkish fighting styles, innovative use of cavalry, expert at seaside combat. Ravenna is trying really hard to get a local figure made a saint, Romauld, a monastic founder, so promising that would get him to work cheap. Ravenna is very strongly affected by what happens to Rimini and to Naples, so he’ll care about those things too. Probably hates the Malatesta, wild neighbors.

WILL ATTACK: Everywhere in Italy, *especially Forlì!* Reluctant to oppose Guelph allies.

SPECIALIZES FIGHTING IN: Coastal places.

Prospero Colonna (Ghibelline): Most prominent Colonna general and effective war leader of the Ghibelline party, extremely experienced, has fought in most sections of Italy, notably both for and against the Sixtus/Riario/della Rovere forces under Sixtus and Innocent. Your uncle Fabrizio Colonna will help him when near Naples, so he’d be extra effective there. The Colonna are the mercenaries who care most about the Guelph-Ghibelline issue so he’s almost certain to fight for Maximilian or Sforza, and will fight cheap if it’s to defend Ghibelline allies.

WON’T ATTACK: Rome, or trustworthy Ghibelline allies, won’t go against the Emperor

SPECIALIZES FIGHTING IN: Central Italy, Kingdom of Naples

Ferrand d’Este (slightly Ghibelline): Second son of the noblest house in Italy, brother of Duke Alfonso and Cardinal Ippolito d’Este, cunning and ambitious. Grew up in Naples from a young

age and is estranged from his brothers, closer with King Ferrante of Naples and his godfather Cardinal Guiliano della Rovere. May be easy for Uncle Giovanni to recruit. You aren't actually sure where he is—last you heard he had a quarrel with Duke Alfonso and is likely under house arrest in Ferrara to keep him from stirring trouble. Only man you know who might actually attack Ferrara—if anyone wanted to help him launch a coup against his brother he'd leap at the chance.

WON'T ATTACK: Savona, or parts of Naples

SPECIALIZES FIGHTING IN: Kingdom of Naples, Ferrara, Mirandola, Padua.

“Gattamelata” (Honeyed Cat) Gian Antonio Da Narni, of Venice (faction neutral): Veteran who has twice suppressed rebellions in Forlì, and fought for Venice, Milan, and the papacy. Famous for cunning tactics which reduce losses during battle by using the wings of his armies cleverly. Very versatile and really just in it for the cash—likely impossible to get him under 40,000.

WON'T ATTACK: Venice, Padua, probably Ferrara.

SPECIALIZES FIGHTING IN: Viterbo, Florence, Forlì, Bologna, Milan, Padua, Rome.

***Francesco Gonzaga, Marquess of Mantua (Ghibelline):** Warrior, general, scholar, and a great patron of the arts and of humanism. Very closely allied with his brother-in-law Guidobaldo. Worked under his father to fight against the aggression of Venice in northern Italy. Currently unmarried and seeking a bride. He really wants a good marriage that will bring strength and elevate Mantua, so if someone offers him a really good match from a noble house more powerful than his own, that will probably get both his two armies *and* Duke Guidobaldo's as well. He cares a bit less about Ghibelline matters than his brother-in-law, and he and Guidobaldo will definitely end up choosing what commission to take jointly, though they're cunning enough they may fight for different buyers if they think doing so will benefit both of them.

****Has two armies:** commander of his reserve force is his younger brother Giovanni Gonzaga—he's likely seeking a bride as well, and they have a sister who needs a husband.

WON'T ATTACK: Mantua, Urbino, may be hesitant to attack Siena due to its ties to Guidobaldo.

SPECIALIZES FIGHTING IN: Northern Italy excluding Ferrara, Mirandola, and Mantua.

***Guidobaldo da Montefeltro, Duke of Urbino (Ghibelline):** Talented condottiero, princely son of the legendary Federico da Montefeltro. Renowned both for his martial talents and fondness for art and humanism, both of which he collects. You know he's a major force, and his choice of whom to fight for may have a bigger effect on the war than anything. He'll care most about his potential adopted heir, and about family marriages, especially Francesco Gonzaga's, and about helping his nephews and brothers-in-law. He'd love a chance to attack Guelph Florence using the plans his father left him (both for family pride and to loot its antiquities), and that he is eager to defend the Sforza against France, but he isn't so passionate about faction that he wouldn't accept French or Florentine offers if they were really good, especially if they offered Gonzaga a great bride. You know he will listen a lot to your advice, but that many factors will be pulling on him.

*****Has two armies:** reserve force commanded by his half-brother Antonio da Montefeltro. Antonio once challenged him for the throne, but you're pretty sure that conflict is long over.

WON'T ATTACK: Urbino, Mantua, or Siena.

SPECIALIZES IN: Tuscany (especially Florence), Urbino, Mantua, against Guelphs.

Carlo Malatesta (semi-Guelph faction traitors): From the port city of Rimini, ruled by his brother, Pandolfo IV Malatesta. The Malatesta were Ghibellines but in 1248 they betrayed their

party and helped the Guelphs massacre many Ghibellines in return for Guelph aid seizing Rimini—since then they are sort-of Guelphs but trusted by no one. They are extraordinarily fierce and tenacious on the battlefield, with a reputation for sacking everything they take. The family itself is quite strange, as they send no sons into church, and their cathedral is nearly a pagan temple. They are passionate warriors who have a history of bloody warfare against all (Pope Pius II invented canonizing someone into Hell for *this family*). The Malatesta are really effective in battle but totally uncontrollable, and anyone who hires them needs to plan carefully or they'll sack everything in sight. They are eager to rule more cities and would be easily persuaded by that.

WILL ATTACK: Everywhere in Italy except his home Rimini; will fight beyond Italy if paid well.

SPECIALIZES FIGHTING IN: Everywhere equally.

Federigo Malavolti (Ghibelline): From an old family of the republic of Siena, which has had a 150 year feud with the more powerful Piccolomini family and are very eager to leave Siena and become rulers of some other town where they won't be under the thumb of their old enemies. You know through your stepmother that the Malavolti commander isn't very skilled, he hasn't had a chance to command much given the family's comparative weakness, so he's not as desirable a commander as many, but he'll be extra eager to do well to improve his reputation and prove reliable. Your stepmother would be very grateful if you get him a good commission that pays well.

WON'T ATTACK: Siena, unless it's to expel the Piccolomini family.

SPECIALIZES FIGHTING IN: Tuscany.

Astorre Manfredi (Guelph): From the ruling family of the small town of Faenza, historic enemies of the city of Forlì, whose city has suffered due to Forlì's rise to prominence, expert at fighting in mountain passes, using traps and fortifications designed for slopes. He'd be really great at Milan defending against the French in the mountain pass. Not exceptional otherwise.

WILL ATTACK: Everywhere in Italy, *especially Forlì!* Reluctant to oppose Guelph allies.

SPECIALIZES FIGHTING IN: Florence, Forlì, mountain passes.

Niccolo Orsini (Guelph): Most prominent Orsini general and effective war leader of the Guelph party, gained much experience as one of the main generals helping King Ferrante of Naples defend against the papacy and the Colonna in the War of the Conspiracy of the Barons. The Orsini are unlikely to be willing to help or work for any Ghibellines no matter what, but they are kinsman through your cousins in Salerno, so they might not be too hostile to you. Very competent.

WON'T ATTACK: Rome, Florence, or trustworthy Guelph allies

SPECIALIZES FIGHTING IN: Rome, Volterra, Kingdom of Naples

Giovanni della Rovere, Duke of Sora (slightly Ghibelline): Younger brother of Cardinal Guiliano della Rovere, ruler of a small duchy in between Naples and Rome. He worked extensively under pope Innocent VIII as Captain-General of the Church, a very skilled man. Really he's a man who likes to fight his own wars, not those of other men, so he's guaranteed to end up fighting for whoever Uncle Julius agrees is wisest, so in a sense this army already belongs to Julius (and in fact Cardinal della Rovere indeed holds his army card), but they'll likely try to see if they can get someone to pay him to do so, since if they can, he'll have the extra money to then hire another mercenary to back him up in battle. Good tactic.

WON'T ATTACK: Genoa, Sora, or Urbino.

SPECIALIZES FIGHTING IN: Florence, Ferrara, and Kingdom of Naples.

Gianfrancesco Sanseverino, Count of Castelnuovo Scrivia, near Naples (Ghibelline): Your eldest half-brother, has served in many campaigns in Naples currently France in the service of King Charles. He's basically guaranteed to fight for Charles, and to try to help get your banished cousin Antonello Lord of Salerno back restored to his home, but it would be nice if he got paid well.

WON'T ATTACK: Home, but he would love to retake Salerno for Antonello.

SPECIALIZES FIGHTING IN: Milan, Padua, Kingdom of Naples

Antonello Savelli (Ghibelline): A strong Colonna partisan, nephew of Cardinal Savelli, experienced from fighting for Innocent in the War of the Conspiracy of the Barons, and many times against the Orsini. His uncle has been using his position as Governor of Bologna to spy on the Bentivoglio family there, so he would probably be very effective attacking Bologna or fighting against any Bentivoglio forces.

WILL ATTACK: Everywhere in Italy except Rome. Eager to fight Guelphs.

SPECIALIZES FIGHTING IN: Bologna, Lazio (around Rome), Kingdom of Naples

Below are known Fledgling Commanders, meaning men who have been training to lead armies but don't yet have armies of their own. Each *could* raise & lead a new army if given 40,000 to purchase horses, armor, weapons, and recruit men. No matter what else you offer, a fledgling mercenary *cannot* accept less than 40,000 or they can't raise the army, unless they somehow get the cash elsewhere.

Paride Alidosi (neutral), younger son of Giovanni Alidosi lord of Castel del Rio, a dinky town under the dominion of Bologna. The Alidosi family have grown in wealth recently due to the support of the Riario. He's very likely to be funded by Uncle Giovanni and Uncle Julius, though would be reluctant to fight directly against the Bentivoglios since that could cause trouble for him at home.

Alessandro Bentivoglio (Guelph), third son of Giovanni First Citizen of Bologna, eager to join the family business as soon as he can get his own army, eager for a knighthood. May end up helping Florence since his father owes Lorenzo de Medici a favor. If the other Bentivoglios get good pay this season, they might be willing to use part of it to help fund his army.

Sciarra da Montefeltro Colonna (Ghibelline), your cousin, son of Fabrizio Colonna Grand Constable of Naples, and Agnese da Montefeltro. Eager to be tried in the field. Has grown up around King Ferrante so really knows how to handle himself around dangerous men. You'd like very much to see his army funded, and you know he's also been training at naval combat and could potentially command a navy very well. The Colonna family would probably be willing to pay 10,000 or maybe even 20,000 of the cost to make sure he gets his debut this war season.

Ottaviano da Montefeltro Fragoso (Ghibelline), young son of Duke Guidobaldo da Montefeltro's widowed sister Gentile by her husband Agostino Fragoso, son of a former Doge

of Genoa. The boy is still a teenager but has been raised by the duke in Urbino and trained for war, and the duke led armies at age eleven. No one will be very sad if his army isn't funded this season, but he is a cousin so you'd like to help him if you can. No field experience yet. If the duke and his brother-in-law Gonzaga get good pay this season, they may contribute some to funding Fragoso's debut.

Troilo Malatesta (semi-Guelph traitor), half-brother of Pandolfo & Carlo Malatesta of Rimini, very promising young commander eager to take the field. Likely to be wild and uncontrollable. Really giving the Malatestas another army is... a questionable choice, but they're very effective!

Antonio Ordelaaffi (faction neutral): Formerly Lord of Forlì, kicked out by Pope Sixtus when he gave the city to Girolamo Riario and Caterina Sforza, would love for someone to fund an army to retake it, or anything. The Ordelaaffi have fought for both Guelph and Ghibelline forces alternating as far back as Dante. Anyone who gives him a crack at Forlì would probably be exciting enough that the Ordelaaffi would dig into their pockets a bit to help fund the army.

Orsino Orsini (Guelph), nephew of Cardinal Orsini and of Cardinal Borgia, had some military experience but his men all deserted him after he was shamed by failing to kill his wife Julia Farnese over her love-affairs. If he killed his wife and her lover, his men would respect and follow him again for only 20,000. But really, you hear he's a useless coward and a shame to the family.

Virginio Orsini (Guelph), nephew of Cardinal Orsini, Guelph champion, much experience fighting in Central Italy and in Naples, his army would have much support from his powerful family. He'll be a major fighting force once he's funded. The Orsini may be willing to pay some of the cost.

Annibale Sanseverino (Ghibelline), One of your elder half-brothers, eager to have an army and make his debut. Definitely getting him funded is a priority for you, but making sure he's in a campaign where he can make his reputation is very important. Ideally it would be good to send him into the field alongside one of his warrior uncles, so they can help him.

Ugo da Montefeltro Sanseverino (Ghibelline), Another of your elder brothers, though unlike Annibale he's been training especially at shore and sea combat, and would probably be very good at defending or attacking port cities, and could be attached as a commander to a navy. You know Ugo dreams of being a crusader knight, and would be very excited to join the Knights Hospitaller, if Cardinal d'Aubusson would consider it.

Silvio Savelli (Ghibelline), grandnephew of Cardinal Savelli, eager to carry on the family tradition of killing Guelphs and serving the Emperor.

Most of the families above may have additional sons interested in leading armies if you fund them.

Certainly yours does!

GOALS (in order of importance):

1. Protect and advance the Sanseverino family (and your family lands near Naples).
2. Protect and advance your extended family, including (in order of importance):
 - a. Duke Guidobaldo and the other Montefeltros of Urbino, and their Gonzaga allies.
 - b. Uncle Giovanni della Rovere and his ambitious kinsmen including Uncle Julius.
 - c. Uncle Fabrizio Colonna and his kin, including Cardinal Colonna.
 - d. The Sforza of Milan, who are your kinsmen and launched your father's career, and are often the best family in Italy for a mercenary to work for.
 - e. Uncle Carafa—he sure has it rough dealing with Mad King Ferrante.
 - f. Your banished uncle Antonello Sanseverino Prince of Salerno is stuck in France, so either needs King Ferrante to forgive him, or King Ferrante to be overthrown.
 - g. The Malatesta are wild, but if you help they're less likely to be enemies.
 - h. The Bentivoglio and Alidosi families aren't kin, but are comrades who fought alongside (or against) your father and grandfathers, and will help you if you help them.
3. Establish yourself in Rome, making friendships and allies. You are at the *start* of your career, and building bridges will yield much more long-term than a bribe right now.
 - a. Get to know the uncles you don't know yet. You'll want to end up living in one of your uncles' Roman palaces long-term, either Colonna, Carafa, or della Rovere.
 - Once you've picked a favorite, ask if you can stay with them.
 - b. Get to know the younger cardinals especially. Might you find a partner for your political labors, as Francesco Gonzaga is to Guidobaldo's military labors?
 - c. When you make new friends, help them with their goals.
 - d. If a strong faction invites you to join, that could be good! But supporting a faction whose members you respect is more important, and helping people in their worst hours can make stronger friendships than flocking around the powerful.
4. Sell your mercenary armies, remembering that mercenaries are people! You will want to frequently check on the particular needs of each mercenary.
 - a. 40,000 is the *minimum* to make a real profit, and keep the men from looting uncontrollably. In special situations 20,000 is the *bare minimum* that feeds an army.
 - b. Mercenaries don't want to fight against their close kinsmen.
 - c. Connections, alliances, and especially marriages can be worth more than gold.
 - d. Mercenaries need titles so others will serve under them. It doesn't matter who granted it, it could be in Scotland or Portugal or the Holy Land, so long as it says "duke of X" it's enough! For reference, the hierarchy of titles goes:
King > Prince > Duke > Marquis/Marquess/Margrave > Count/Earl > Lord > Knight
5. Keep track of which new saints are being canonized and make sure people important to you aren't fighting against armies excited about having new saints—that goes badly.
6. You have *lots* of siblings and cousins to marry off. That said, you don't need to take bad matches just to get it done—marriages are only worthwhile when they gain something.
7. Getting knighthoods or minor (lord/count/earl) titles for as many brothers as possible would be great; you have eight brothers who still need knighthoods or titles to lead men.
8. Help the Ghibelline party (over the Guelphs) since your extended family are Ghibellines.
9. Obtain whatever other resources you can: Money, Allies, Items, Courtiers, anything.

Opinion Guelphs v. Ghibellines: Ghibelline! Your kinsmen have battled Guelphs for generations!

Opinion on Franciscans vs. Dominicans: Whatever. You're a Benedictine, but Uncle Carafa runs the Dominicans, and Aunt Elizabetta is a Franciscan, so they're all fine.

Opinions Orsini vs Colonna: Colonna are kinsmen and Ghibelline allies, the Orsini are *also* kinsmen through Uncle Sanseverino of Salerno (the one in exile), but factional enemies.

Allies

You may communicate freely with your allies during and between sessions. If someone becomes your ally through marriage or through clientage, add them to this list.

Cardinal Giuliano della Rovere (Uncle Julius)
Cardinal Raffaele Riario
Cardinal Colonna
Cardinal Oliviero Carafa
Cardinal Ascanio Sforza
Cardinal Campofregoso (kinsman/enemy of Aunt Gentile's 2nd h.)
Cardinal Ippolito d'Este (as a Malatesta & Sforza kinsman)
Cardinal Piccolomini (Guidobaldo's godfather, stepmom's enemy)
Cardinal Orsini (Related to Antonello Sanseverino of Solerno)
Cardinal "Leo" de Medici (his brother married your distant cousin)
Emperor Maximilian (as the Guelph faction's Caesar)
Queen Isabella of Castile (and Kings Ferdinand & Ferrante)
King Charles of France (as patron of your eldest brother)
Patriarch of Venice

Contacts

You may DM, email, call, or otherwise communicate freely with your contacts during sessions, but do not contact them outside of sessions.

RESOURCES AND WEAKNESSES:

Rank: Noble

Combat Value: 1*

Territory: Castelnuovo Scrivia, near Naples.

Resources:

- Money: 20,000 Florins cash, plus each of your Sanseverino sisters has 15,000 left by your father for her dowry (though they'll need more than that to marry well.) Many of the other brides from your extended family have dowries partly or fully covered by their kinsmen—see their cards.
- Courtiers: six. (Your father brought them back from his wars to tutor his kids, but now that most of you are grown they aren't as necessary, so you could trade them away if you had good reason, but you'd also be happy to keep them to raise your brother's kids etc.)
 - o **Johannes Reuchlin**, scholar of Greek, Latin, Hebrew, Kabbala, Magic, & Angelology
 - o **Konrad Seusenhofer**, armorer
 - o **Marbrianus de Orto**, Burgundian musician
 - o **Leon Battista Alberti**, artist, architect, engineer
 - o **Bartolomeo Scappi**, Italian banquet chef
 - o **Ambrosio Varesi**, physician & astrologer
- Assassins & Spies: 0
- Unsigned Contracts:
 - o Granting armies safe passage through Urbino and Mantua for Uncle Guidobaldo
- Public Papal Petitions: none.
- Armies: All the ones listed above. **Remember that when someone hires mercenaries from you, that money goes to the mercenaries, not into your pockets!** Do not betray your family and friends.
- Ports: You hold the port card for Salerno, in case it needs to change hands, but you can only trade it with permission from King Ferrante and your cousin the current (exiled) Prince of Salerno.
- Brides: fourteen!
 - o Three unmarried full sisters:
 - Ludovica, Eleonora, and Ippolita da Montefeltro Sanseverino
 - o Four unmarried half-sisters:
 - Elizabetta, Stefania, Francesca, and Flora Malavolti Sanseverino
 - o Cousins through your stepmother: Panchina and Caterina Malavolti, of Siena
 - o Cousins through Uncle Guidobaldo:
 - Bettina, Caterina, & Costanza Fregoso, daughters of Aunt Gentile's Genose 2nd husband
 - Giovanna & Dorotea Malatesta, half-sisters of Pandolfo Malatesta Lord of Rimini
- Grooms: fourteen!
 - o Two unmarried full brothers:
 - Ugo and Giorgio da Montefeltro Sanseverino
 - o Two unmarried younger half-brothers: Giulio & Ottaviano.
 - Your elder half-brothers Count Gianfrancesco (in France), the joustier Fracasso (in Germany), plus Antonio Maria, Alessandro, and Annibale (off leading armies) will probably arrange their own marriages, or ask your traitor brother Galahad to do so using his contacts in Milan (Galahad is married to a Sforza bride)
 - o Two cousins through your stepmother: Donosdeo and Azzolino Malavolti of Siena
 - o Six cousins through Uncle Guidobaldo:
 - Carlo Malatesta, mercenary, full brother & favorite of Pandolfo Malatesta
 - Troilo Malatesta, young mercenary half-brother of Pandolfo Malatesta
 - Sigismundo Malatesta, child, very young heir to the city of Rimini
 - Ottaviano, Battista, & Federigo Fregoso, sons of Aunt Gentile's Genose 2nd husband

- o You have also been asked by His Grace Duke Guidobaldo to find a worthy bride for his brother-in-law and military partner Francesco Gonzaga Marquess of Mantua, one of the most high-status grooms in all of Italy, and the Marquess's brother Giovanni Gonzaga.
- o Benedictine nunnery of San Maurizio, in Milan
- Possessions: lots
 1. **Father's Diary of the Holy Land**
 2. **Extremely Comfortable Classical Chariot:** Worth 8,000, so shiny! So padded!
 3. **Excellent Courser:** Worth 4,000, a spare mount that makes a commander who is riding with an army likely to be able to escape if they lose a battle. Your brothers bred it; can't use it yourself.
 4. **Reliquary of the Cilice of Saint Sigismund King of Burgundy:** Worth 3,000.
 5. **Venetian Shadow Boat:** Small stealth craft, can navigate very shallow water quickly, and transport people with such speed and stealth that warships blockading a place can't stop them from going in or out. Can't fight, only transport. Gift to your father from Venice.
 6. **Ancient Roman Carved Gems:** Gift to your father from Piero de Medici.
 7. **Tiger Cub:** Your dad brought tigers back from when he worked for the Duchess of Savoy, and they have had lots of kittens, so you all have plenty of tigers.
 8. **Enough Peacocks:** Some would say too many peacocks, enough to start a colony.
 9. **Clothes for a Young Girl made of fine Florentine Fabrics and Genoese Velvet:** Slightly worn but still gorgeous. Your youngest sister has outgrown them.
 10. **Clothes for a Young Boy made of fine Florentine Fabrics and Genoese Velvet:** Slightly worn but still gorgeous. Your youngest brother has outgrown them.
 11. **Petrarch's *Secretum* manuscript in his own hand**
 12. **Back Brace:** anyone searching your person will notice you wear it.

Property in Rome (vulnerable to the mob): None! You plan to stay with one of your uncles. But which?

Evidence of Crime: None. It wasn't simony, it was blackmail. Blackmail's fine.

Special Powers:

- **Spinal Compression:** You can't ride with armies in the war phase.

OPINIONS OF THE OTHER CHARACTERS:

1. **Rodrigo BORGIA (age 61):** You don't know much beyond he's a competent administrator and from Aragon so tied to the king who's propping up Ferrante. He's an associate of Uncle Carafa. Likely ok?
2. **Oliviero CARAFA (age 62):** Your uncle. Hard-working man who protects your family from Mad King Ferrante. He's trustworthy, looks out for you, and you'd like to help make his life less stressful.
3. **Giovanni COLONNA (AGE 57):** Uncle Fabrizio Colonna's uncle, so your great-uncle, you hear only grand and princely things about him, you look forward to meeting him. Should be an easy ally.
4. **Francesco "SAMSON" Nanni (age 78):** From Siena, likely an ally of the Piccolomini who oppress your stepmother's Malavolti relatives, or could also hate Piccolomini? Franciscan, ally of Uncle Julius.
5. **Giambattista ORSINI (AGE 57):** The Guelph leader, likely to be an enemy, though he's a kinsman of your banished uncle Antonello Sanseverino Prince of Salerno, so may help get him back home?
6. **Francesco Todeschini PICCOLOMINI (AGE 63):** From the powerful Sienese family that oppresses your stepmother's Malavolti relatives, though you hear personally that he's a scholar and well liked.
7. **"Julius" Giuliano DELLA ROVERE (age 49):** Uncle Julius is almost a legend by this point, you've heard Uncle Giovanni discuss him so much, his ambition and genius. #1 on your list of people to meet!
8. **Ascanio SFORZA (AGE 41):** Kin through your grandparents, his family launched your father's career. You owe him much, but will he treat you like a peer, or like a servant assuming you'll help him due to your family's debts? Your brother and one of your cousins are with King Charles, who's Sforza's foe.
9. **THE INQUISITOR GENERAL Gioacchino Torriani (age 60):** Bet he cares a lot about theology. Better make sure he doesn't notice how little you care about it. Dominican, under Uncle Carafa.

(Not Yet Declared Papabile:)

10. **Pierre D'AUBUSSON (69):** A crusader knight! Wow! You can't wait to meet him! If only he would tutor your brothers, or let them into the knights?! They qualify! He must know awesome techniques!
11. **Guillaume BRIÇONNET (47):** Celebrated general, it will be neat to meet him. Your brother and cousin might end up fighting for him if France invades, though other brothers may end up against...
12. **Paolo CAMPOFREGOSO (age 62):** Cousin-in-law through a widowed aunt, pirate, admiral, his family betray each other and everyone else a lot, hence his exiled. Kinsman but a wildcard.
13. **Jorge DA COSTA (age 86):** Portuguese. Um... Likely enemy of Uncle Carafa?
14. **Maffeo Gherardi, THE PATRIARCH of Venice (age 97):** One of the Venetians who didn't send enough backup with your father when he died. Was on the council that ordered your grandfather Federico da Montefeltro into the swamp where he died. While formal revenge on a man so old and powerful isn't wise, you'd love to see him have a miserable time. Benedictine.
15. **Giovanni "ACHILLES" Sangiorgio (age 53):** From Milan, so Sforza's man. He's the one in charge of saint-making, and saints matter a *lot* for war.
16. **Francesco SODERINI (51):** Florence has no nobles so has to hire a lot of mercenaries. Your father fought for the Medici (Soderini's enemy) then against Florence, so has fought against this man twice.
17. **Giovanni BATTISTA ZEN (53):** Venice caused your father's death, but they hire a lot of armies.

(Too young to be Papabile:)

18. **Pietro BEMBO (age 22):** Another extremely new cardinal, a poet & scholar, could be fun!
19. **Michel DE BUCY (21):** Wow, a real royal prince! If you could become friends it could be great!
20. **Adriano "HADRIAN" Castellesi (32):** England? None of your mercenary relatives want to go there.
21. **Ippolito D'ESTE (AGE 22):** A real d'Este prince! And a Benedictine, like you! You would love to become friends! His brother Ferrante d'Este is a mercenary but estranged, family squabbles?
22. **"Leo" Giovanni di Lorenzo DE MEDICI (17):** Part commoner, part Orsini, technically your cousin-in-law but you'd feel weird acknowledging a merchant as a peer. Florence pays a lot for its mercenaries and the cash comes from the Medici. You'll want to make sure all that Medici gold goes to your relatives, not the Swiss, if possible. Then again, several of your uncles would *love* to be hired to sack Florence, especially Duke Guidobaldo who has his father's war plans of Florence, and Uncle

Giovanni della Rovere hates them too. Though the Medici are so rich even Duke Guidobaldo would fight for Florence if they pay enough. He's your age, so you'll be colleagues a long time.

23. **Raffaele RIARIO (31):** Your cousin through della Rovere and near your age, likely to be a lifelong political ally and partner—you can't wait to meet him! It would be really bad if you don't get along.
24. **Federico (da Montefeltro) SANSEVERINO (age 18):** Yourself.
25. **Matthäus Schiner (age 35):** Your main competitor, here to sell Swiss mercenaries. The Swiss fight anywhere, without faction or party. It's embarrassing for them if they end up on both sides of a battle since then they sit out—if you could arrange for that, it would make people more eager to hire Italians.

(Functionaries:)

26. **Cesare Borgia "VALENTINO", Papal Treasurer (age 17):** Aragonese so an ally of Uncle Carafa.
27. **Papal Chaplain Alessandro FARNESE (AGE 18):** Uncle Fabrizio says the Farnese family are scum, and a disgrace to Rome, but your stepmother says they're powerful and he may become a cardinal.
28. **CAPTAIN Micheletto Corella (22):** Not a family you know—odd. The choice to hire a Spanish captain might be an attempt by the papacy to be neutral among Italian warriors until the election?
29. **Chief Apostolic Secretary Gherardo MAFFEI (age 71):** Volterra is so Guelph their flag is just literally the Guelph flag! That's about all you know, really.
30. **Master of Ceremonies Johann BURCHARD (age 42):** Bet his job is complicated and cool.
31. **Papal Choir Director JOSQUIN des Prez (age 42):** Your music tutor, he's Burgundian and is great!
32. **Clerk CONSTANTINE (AGE 33):** No idea.
33. **Clerk Brother TILLIO (age 21):** No idea.

(Monarchs:)

34. **THE EMPEROR Maximilian I (age 41):** Head of the Ghibelline party, though your father died fighting his soldiers. Your big brother Fracasso is with him in the Empire as his jousting coach.
35. **Charles VIII of FRANCE (age 22):** Your eldest brother Count Gianfrancesco is with him in France. If he invades Italy that could be good in Naples but bad in Milan? Either way your family gets \$\$
36. **Isabella I, Queen of CASTILE (41):** One of very few people who can control King Ferrante.
37. **Henry VII, King of ENGLAND (AGE 43):** The cliffs make England basically un-invadable and who would want to be hired up there, it's wet and cold and full of civil war?
38. **Anne of BRITTANY, Queen of France (age 19):** Your brother gets to be around this queen.
39. **Beatrice of Naples, Twice Queen of HUNGARY (35):** King Ferrante's daughter, though she left his court for Hungary before you came so you don't know her. Good reputation. Uncle Carafa likes her.
40. **THE ROMAN MOB (AGE 2,252):** You *never* want to have to take an army into Rome!